To Drown in Your Eyes

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To Drown in Your Eyes

by Lunaeryi

Summary

Κάνε μια επιλογή.
Make a choice.
Let it be the match to your martyrdom.
Let it be the vow that breaks the gods.

Or in which a certain Crown Prince and Deliverer are helplessly in love with each other.

Notes

Yall check out this AMAZING fanart by radio-zephyr, ITS SO GOOD OMG???
https://www.tumblr.com/radio-zephyr/783175534827995136/%CF%80%CE%B1%CF%81%CE%B1%CE%BB%CE%AE%CF%81%CE%B7%CE%BC%CE%B1-delirium-the-body-remembering-what-the

Chapter 1: Make a Choice

Chapter Summary

> Phainon and Mydei start off by almost killing each other in a ten-day duel after seeing each other for the first time in years, followed by Phainon accidentally groping Mydei and running for his life, but eventually they get closer—though that doesn't last long when Mydei has to leave to inherit the throne and Phainon's left staring at an empty road. Classic.

Chapter Notes

> Ok I don't even know what this is. It was just gonna be a 5k smut ff with Sac Lamb Phainon but it dove into this?? I feel the plot got a bit outlandish but I literally spent way too long writing this to redo it so uhh yeah, enjoy
>
> PS: I want whatever some other Phaidei writers are on cause how the fuck do you guys write so fast😭 THIS TOOK ME A WHOLE WEEKKKKK (And some days more)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The temple stood like a wound in the sky—white marble veined with red, sacred smoke bleeding through its open roof to be caught by the breathless heavens above. It was dawn, though in Aedes Elysiae, the sun did not rise so much as it *remembered*—soft and late, filtering through the mountain mists like a memory too gentle to name.

Inside, the holy chamber was silent. Not empty, never that. But silent in the way that demanded reverence. The air was heavy with myrrh and iron, the scent of sacrifice, of prophecy, of something greater than either.

Phainon stood barefoot at the altar's edge.

The cold from the stone had long since sunk into his skin. He did not move. Not because he could not—but because it felt wrong to disturb the stillness of a world that had already decided his fate.

The high priest moved forward at last. Their voice was low, weathered by years of prayer, of choosing, of *letting go.*

“You go willingly,” they said. It was not a question.

Phainon’s gaze remained fixed on the long, pale corridor before him. On the pool of light spilling through the open archway. On the steps he would soon take. On the end. Or the beginning. Perhaps both.

“I do.”

His voice did not tremble. Not here. Not now.

“If I burn,” he murmured, “let it be for something greater than silence.”

The priest nodded. And without further word, the ceremony began.

He was undressed, robed again in white so fine it was nearly translucent. Around his neck, they placed the old tokens—the tokens of the Deliverer: a pendant carved in the shape of the rising sun, its edges dulled by the lips of a thousand prayers. A belt of reeds, fresh from the riverbanks. Ash from the last sacrifice pressed to the center of his brow.

And last—his wrists.

A priestess knelt before him, her touch careful as she wrapped the red thread around each arm. One turn for protection. One for devotion. One for the gods to see.

Three knots. Always three.

“The color of chosen blood,” someone whispered behind him.

No one disagreed.

Above him, the golden flame of the pyre flickered high into the dome of the temple. It did not warm him. Nothing had, not since the decree was made.

But he was not afraid.

He was not afraid, because the stars had whispered of this day before he ever learned to read. Because Cyrene had cried when she first called him Deliverer, and said, *“I hope there will never be a need for you.”*

Because once, long ago, a boy in a tree had dared him to climb higher, and Phainon had never learned how to say no to fire.

A bell tolled.

Then a second.

Then silence again.

The high priest lifted their hand. And the whole of Aedes Elysiae stilled as the chamber echoed with a voice not entirely mortal. One that did not come from throat or tongue—but bone. Blood. Sky.

It spoke in ancient breath, in command, in prophecy:

“Make a choice.”

———

Κάνε μια επιλογή.
Make a choice.
Let it be the match to your martyrdom.
Let it be the vow that breaks the gods.

———

Sometimes, when the temple is quiet and the fire low, he remember the tree.

Not just the tree, but the air around it—how it hummed with cicadas and sun. How the wind curled itself around his ankles like a cat. How the world

felt huge, wild and open and his.

He remembered the boy in it, too.

He remembered everything.

Even now, with thread on his wrists and fate in my mouth, he remembered it not as a dream—but as the moment he began to *choose*.

It was meant to be a pilgrimage.

A secret one. A sacred one. The Deliverer, once a generation, was to walk the old path between Aedes Elysiae and the ruins of Kalamaris, where the river split the mountains and old gods wept into the sea. It was a rite of silence—one foot in front of the other, with only dreams for company.

But Phainon, twelve and curious and burning brighter than the sky, did not follow the river.

He followed the *wind*.

It was said to blow down from the fortress kingdom of Castrum Kremnos only once every cycle. Sharp, cold, ancient. It carried scents he did not know the names for—metal, stone, sweat, lavender.

He walked toward it like a moth.

The hills unfurled under him in golds and greens. The sky opened wider than he’d ever seen. No temple walls. No carved columns. Just the world, raw and untamed. Phainon stumbled over tree roots and laughed when he fell. He pressed his palms to the dirt and said hello to the earth. He tasted berries he wasn’t supposed to. He gasped when he saw his first wild horse.

Wonder. That was the only word for it. Wonder and *want*.

Then he saw the tree.

Not just a tree—but the tree. Wide-limbed and old, its branches curved like a sleeping lion. At its highest point sat a boy, stretched lazily along the branch, one leg dangling, back half-turned to the world as if it were already his and he had grown bored of it.

Phainon stopped.

It wasn't just curiosity. It was more than that—*it always had been more than that.*

The boy above him glowed.

A very pretty boy.

Phainon stared.

The boy didn't move. Didn't acknowledge him.

And that, perhaps, was the real offense.

Because Phainon was used to being noticed, to being known as something *important*—the Deliverer, the bright one, the spark in the dark.

So he squinted up at the branch and called out, "Hey! You ignoring me or just asleep?"

No response.

Phainon huffed. "I know you can hear me. Don't pretend you're a statue."

Still nothing.

So he did the only thing he could think of.

He started climbing.

And well, Phainon had never been particularly graceful.

He could balance offerings and walk barefoot across marble floors without flinching, but trees? Trees were a different thing entirely. His knees were scraped by the time he made it halfway up. His hair was full of leaves, his arms scratched and dirty—but the boy lounging above him hadn't even glanced down.

Phainon squinted up at him. The boy was stretched out on the thickest branch like he belonged there. Pale hair, streaked crimson at the tips, and red markings over his arms and shoulders like he'd been painted by some ceremonial brush. Muscled for his age, sharp-jawed, expression so smug it made Phainon's hands itch.

Beautiful. Annoyingly so.

"Hey!" Phainon called up, clinging to a knot in the bark. "Are you always this rude or are you *actually* a statue?"

No response.

Phainon narrowed his eyes. He hauled himself up two more branches and cupped his hands around his mouth.

"I *know* you heard me!"

Still nothing.

"Oh *come on*," Phainon muttered. "What are you, scared?" And then louder: "What—you chickening out?"

There was the faintest twitch from the boy above.

He cracked one eye open, gave Phainon a single withering look, and then said, like he was announcing something of national importance:

"The Kremnoans don't have a word for 'chickening out.'"

Phainon blinked. "That's the stupidest thing I've ever heard."

The boy snorted and promptly closed his eyes again.

Phainon’s patience snapped.

He scrambled up the last few branches and threw himself right onto the smug tree-dweller, arms flailing, shouting, “You arrogant little—!”

There was a wild yelp as the other boy’s eyes flew open, and both of them slipped, tumbled, grabbed—barely managing to cling to the edge of the branch.

“What the hell is wrong with you?!” the boy shouted, gripping the bark with one hand and Phainon’s arm with the other.

“You were ignoring me!”

“You tried to kill us!”

“You were asking for it, lying there all mysterious!”

“I was napping!”

They wobbled dangerously. The pretty boy—or the stranger, at least—gritted his teeth and dragged them both back up with a groan. They collapsed in a heap, gasping.

“You’re insane,” the boy muttered, rubbing his face.

“You’re rude,” Phainon replied, sprawled across his stomach like a smug cat. “Not a great combo, by the way.”

The boy stared at him. “You really climbed up here just to *annoy* me?”

Phainon grinned. “Yes. And it worked.”

Silence. Then:

“Mydeimos,” the boy said suddenly, sitting up a little. “Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos.”

Phainon tilted his head. “No you’re not.”

“Yes, I *am*.”

“No way.”

“I am.”

“Don’t princes have, I don’t know, crowns?”

“We don’t *wear* crowns,” Mydeimos growled. “Only in ceremonies. Gods.”

“Well, you look like a tree goblin,” Phainon said, brushing a leaf from his clothes.

Mydeimos shoved him. “You’re the worst.”

“I get that a lot.”

They glared at each other for a long second.

Then both cracked a grin at the same time.

They sat in silence for a while, backs against the trunk, the rustle of wind through leaves filling the quiet. Mydeimos was picking bark off the branch like it had offended him. Phainon leaned over, elbow on his knee, chin in his hand.

“So, mystery prince,” Phainon said, “guess it’s only fair I tell you who you almost died with.”

Mydeimos side-eyed him. “Can’t wait.”

“Phainon,” he said, proudly. “From Aedes Elysiae.”

Mydeimos blinked. “That’s far.”

“Yeah. I kinda… got lost?”

“You got *very* lost.”

Phainon shrugged. “I was following a trail. Got distracted. There were birds. And a hill. And then a bigger hill. And then suddenly I wasn’t in Aedes anymore.”

“Sounds about right,” Mydeimos muttered.

Phainon grinned. “Anyway, Cyrene says I’m the Deliverer.” He said that like he was talking about the weather.

Mydeimos turned to stare at him. “What?”

“Yeah, I don’t really get it either.” Phainon waved a hand like it was no big deal. “She always talks like it’s important. Like—‘I pray the world never has need for a Deliverer again’—very dramatic, right?”

“She’s right.”

Phainon blinked. “You know what it means?”

Mydeimos didn’t answer at first. He just stared at Phainon a little too long before looking away, jaw tense.

“Well *I* don’t,” Phainon said. “And honestly, it sounds like a boring title. Deliverer of what? Mail? Lunch? Grand prophecies that end badly?”

“Death,” Mydeimos muttered under his breath.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

Phainon squinted. “You’re weird.”

“You climbed a tree to annoy a stranger.”

“I was *investigating*.” A beat. “Also, I’m twelve.”

“That explains *so much*.”

They both burst into laughter, the sound echoing through the trees like it belonged there.

Phainon kicked his legs lazily over the branch, glancing sideways at the boy who'd resumed pretending he didn't exist.

"I challenge you," Phainon announced suddenly, puffing his chest out a little.

Mydeimos didn't even blink. "To what. Annoying me to death?"

"No," Phainon huffed. "A swimming competition."

That got his attention—sort of. Mydeimos turned his head with a long, unimpressed blink, like he was being asked to duel a squirrel. "No."

"What, scared?"

And *that* did it.

Mydeimos stiffened. His eyes narrowed. "Kremnoans don't have a word for fear in our language."

Phainon grinned. "So you admit you're scared of losing?"

"I'm not scared of anything."

"Sure, sure."

"I could beat you with both arms tied."

"Do it, then."

Mydeimos let out a sigh like the fate of the world had just been placed on his shoulders. Still, he stood up easily, balancing on the branch with practiced ease. He dropped down branch by branch, light and quick and smooth—Phainon could only watch as the older boy hit the ground and rolled his shoulders like a lion in the sun.

He stretched, lazy and cocky, and flashed a sideways, lopsided smirk up at the tree. “Well? Coming, *Deliverer*?”

Phainon’s heart gave one solid thump. He blinked.

Then: “…I can’t get down.”

Mydeimos blinked once. “What?”

“I don’t know how to climb *down*,” Phainon muttered, gripping the branch like it would save his life. “Getting up was easier.”

Mydeimos stared up at him, all golden and disgusted. “You challenged *me* and you can’t even descend a tree?”

“I never said I could desc-descaend? Whatever that means—a tree!”

Mydeimos groaned and muttered something under his breath in clipped, ancient Kremnoan. “Unbelievable.”

Still, he circled beneath the tree, arms raised slightly. “Fine. Jump. I’ll catch you.”

Phainon hesitated. “Will you *really* catch me?”

“*I just said I would!*” Mydeimos shouted. “Kremnoans don’t have a word for *liar*, either!”

“That seems incredibly impractical—okay, okay, I’m jumping!”

He pushed off the branch and yelped, and true to his word, Mydeimos caught him—*barely*, both of them tumbling to the ground in a tangled heap of limbs and curses and laughter.

“I take it back,” Mydeimos muttered under his breath as Phainon grinned above him, “your title’s not Deliverer. It’s idiot.”

“Deliverer of fun, maybe,” Phainon offered helpfully.

“Nikador give me strength.”

The clearing they stumbled into opened into a wide, sun-drenched river, its current slow and shining like molten silver beneath the sky. Phainon let out a breathless, awed sound. He’d never seen water this clear before—Aedes Elysiae was all mist and springs, but this, this was a thing out of stories.

Mydeimos didn’t even pause. He strode up to the edge and, with deliberate grace, peeled off his outer tunic, stretching with his arms high above his head, spine arching like a bow pulled taut. The red markings on his back shifted with the motion, like fire lit beneath his skin.

Phainon, watching from behind, made a strangled little noise in his throat.

“Are you showing off?” he asked accusingly.

“Warming up,” Mydeimos replied coolly, twisting his torso like a trained athlete, muscle, or as much as you can have as a scrawny warrior child, rippling under sun-drenched skin. “Wouldn’t want to cramp while leaving you in the dust.”

“You’re such a—Mydeimos, dear Kephale, your name is too long.”

Mydeimos turned his head, one brow raised. “Excuse me?”

“Too long,” Phainon repeated, hands on his hips. “What am I supposed to do, shout *My-dei-mos* every time I beat you? Nah. Mydei. I’m calling you Mydei.”

The Crown Prince stared at him as if he’d just been physically struck. “The disrespect.”

“Sure, Mydei. Let’s start.”

Mydei scoffed but stalked toward the water without another word. He dove in first, cutting through the surface like a blade. Phainon rushed after, splashing in with far less elegance but no less determination.

They raced down the river, kicking up foam and curses, dunking each other at every opportunity. Phainon swam like someone who'd grown up chasing fish through brooks, laughing through mouthfuls of water. Mydei swam like war—silent, deadly, focused. Until Phainon dragged him under by the ankle and he came up sputtering and shrieking with curses in clipped Kremnoan, chasing him all the way to the bend in the river.

By the time they hauled themselves back onto the bank, both were breathless, drenched, and gloriously alive.

They flopped side by side on the warm grass, arms spread wide, panting into the sky.

"I won," Mydei declared between gasps.

"In your dreams," Phainon wheezed.

"Your flailing almost drowned us both."

"You call it flailing, I call it strategy."

Mydei let out a bark of laughter, the kind that surprised even himself.

The sun sank lower, bathing them in gold, water dripping from their clothes and hair, the hush of dusk curling soft around them.

"Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," Mydei murmured after a while.

Phainon tilted his head toward him, smiling. "Yeah?"

"That name's almost as long as mine."

"I'm glad we're both ridiculous, then."

Mydei's lips curled. "Disaster and Devastation. That's what they'll call us."

Phainon grinned. "Sounds about right."

The stars were beginning to come out—tiny silver flecks scattered across the darkening blue, like someone had shaken a god's jewelry box too hard.

Phainon lay on his back in the grass, damp from their swim and still catching his breath. He was grinning at nothing, his legs swinging idly, occasionally kicking at a puff of dandelion seeds floating past. His curls stuck to his forehead. A blade of grass hung from his lips like some kind of badge of honor.

"We could probably jump and land on one of those stars," he mused aloud.

Mydei, sprawled beside him with his arms behind his head, side-eyed him. "You'd shatter your ankles."

"Not if I land right." Phainon turned his head, smirking. "You Kremnoans have no imagination."

"We have precision."

"Boring," Phainon said with a grin.

They fell into a companionable quiet. Somewhere near the river, frogs began their nightly symphony. The sky was a soft, endless stretch overhead, the kind that made you feel like you were just small enough to disappear into it.

Phainon turned toward Mydei, voice quieter. "Hey. Can I tell you a secret?"

Mydei didn't look over, just raised an eyebrow. "You're not about to say something strange, are you?"

"No," Phainon said quickly, then paused. "…Maybe? I dunno."

Mydei hummed, giving him the floor.

"I don't wanna be the Deliverer," Phainon confessed, squinting at the sky as if he was trying to read the stars. "Cyrene says I am, that the Seer told her so. That it means something. Big. Important. Fate and destiny."

He plucked a dandelion from the grass and blew it in Mydei's direction. "But I just wanna stay in Aedes Elysiae. Grow old with my friends. Maybe become the best fisher in the village. I'm already terrible at it, so I can only get better, right?"

Mydei was quiet for a moment. Then, almost too softly: "Do you always run from what's meant for you?"

Phainon rolled onto his side to look at him. "I'm not running. I just—" He struggled for the word, then shrugged. "I like my life."

There was a beat of silence. Then Mydei said, deadpan, "The Kremnoans don't have a word for 'like' either."

Phainon laughed, elbowing him. "Do you have a word for anything?"

A pause. Mydei gave him that lopsided grin again. "We have a word for war."

Phainon tilted his head. "That fits."

They both fell back against the grass again. The stars above blinked, listening.

There was nothing else. No prophecy. No fate. Just two boys lying in the quiet, not yet knowing what they would become, or what choices they would have to make.

Not yet.

Phainon was in the middle of tracing a squiggly line in the dirt with a stick —declaring it the "Serpent of the South"—when the soft, padded steps of something enormous caught his ear. He looked up.

From between the trees, tall and graceful as a god's dream, a Dromas padded into the clearing. Its long neck bowed gently beneath pale purple plumage, eyes large and glassy with a kindness that almost made it feel human. Atop it sat a woman cloaked in soft silvers and ash-gold threads,

her hair braided down her back like a chain of memory. She had the look of home, of temple smoke and honeyed offerings.

“Phainon,” she said, smiling with a kind sort of sternness, “you strayed quite far.”

His breath caught. “You’re from Aedes Elysiae.”

“I am one of the High Priestesses,” she replied. “Cyrene told us where to look.” Cyrene? Oh no, she was probably worried.

Phainon blinked, suddenly aware of how far he’d wandered, how long it had been. A quiet ache bloomed in his chest. He stood slowly, brushing off his tunic, eyes drifting toward Mydei without thinking.

The prince hadn’t moved, but his posture was alert, shoulders a little straighter than usual, eyes faintly narrowed in thought. He looked less like a boy and more like something beginning to grow sharp at the edges. Still, you can spot the childish downturn of his lips as he realized his new friend had to go.

“I didn’t mean to get lost,” Phainon said, half to the woman, half to Mydei.

She dismounted with ease, offering a hand that Phainon took reluctantly. “Come now. The stars are rising, and the road is long.”

He let her guide him to the creature’s side, but hesitated before climbing up. His gaze flicked to Mydei again—who was still watching, unreadable.

Then, in a burst of instinct, Phainon tugged free.

“Phainon—” the priestess started, but he was already running.

Across the clearing. Through the fading light. Straight to Mydei.

The prince blinked as Phainon reached up and grabbed both of his arms, holding him like he might disappear.

“We say this in Aedes Elysiae,” Phainon said, breathless, eyes shining. *“Na vrethoume sýntoma.”*

Mydei stared at him. “What does it mean?”

Phainon grinned, squeezing his arms once. “May we meet again soon.”

A beat.

Then—softly, awkwardly, but earnestly—Mydei nodded. *“Na vrethoume sýntoma.”*

Phainon beamed. “You’re learning.”

He let go and ran back to the Dromas, clambering up with the priestess’s help. She said nothing, only offered a faint smile and rested a hand gently on his shoulder as they turned and started to leave.

From his perch, Phainon looked back.

Mydei was still standing there, arms folded now, but his chin lifted just slightly—as if he were watching a star drift out of reach.

Phainon waved.

Mydei didn’t wave back, but he didn’t look away either.

The clearing faded behind them, and the trees swallowed the space where two boys had once dreamed of stars.

———

Να βρεθούμε σύντομα.
Na vrethoume sýntoma.
Let us meet again soon.
Let it be the hope that carries across lifetimes.
Let it be the seed of fate sown in innocent hands.

———

For a long time after that summer day, Phainon never saw that boy again.

Seasons passed. He grew. The world did too—harder, hungrier, louder.

And then the war came.

The Chrysos War.

A decade of ruin spun from golden blood. Twelve names prophesied across the lands of Ampherous, twelve Heirs who would either shatter the old gods or become them. The war wasn’t one of mortals and kings alone—it was a reckoning. The Titans of Calamity stirred in their graves, and all who carried the golden ichor were dragged into the fray.

Aedes Elysiae, once untouched and hidden between valleys of hymn and prayer, was no longer spared.

Phainon, known now only as the Deliverer, was sent to the front.

He hadn’t seen that boy again.

But the battlefield was no place for longing.

Not yet.

It was the third winter of the Chrysos War when Phainon stopped keeping count of the lives he’d taken.

He wasn’t sure if that was the moment he truly became the Deliverer, or if it had happened earlier—when his blood first glowed gold beneath his skin, when his village sent him off with prayers and ribbons, or when he watched his blade slip through the throat of a man who smiled just before he fell.

The war did not turn boys into men. It turned men into stories, and stories into myths, and myths into ash.

Phainon sat by a fire burning low in a ruined chapel, one hand wrapped around a rusted, steaming cup of barley drink. His fingers were still stained

from earlier—brown-red at the tips, with streaks of gold running through the blood.

Gold. The ichor of the Chrysos Heirs.

He hated how it glowed sometimes. How it made it harder to disappear.

“Deliverer,” the priest had whispered, clutching his robes when they passed through that village last week. “You’re the Deliverer.”

As if that name meant anything anymore. As if it hadn’t become just another omen. Phainon delivered peace. He delivered vengeance. He delivered corpses to their gods, and prayers to their silence.

Cyrene found him outside once, near the edge of the ruined city of Therameion. He was bent over a soldier—not a foe, but a boy younger than him, breath caught on the edge of death.

“You always find the dying,” she’d said, kneeling beside him.

He looked up. “No. I think they find me.”

Sometimes he still smiled. Still hummed lullabies from Aedes Elysiae when the blood wouldn’t leave his hands. He slept with his back to walls, curled like he used to when he was a child dreaming of trees and red-marked strangers.

There were moments, brief but aching, when he’d catch a glimpse of something—silver-gold light through smoke, a sword stance too familiar, a voice carried on the wind—and his heart would forget how much time had passed.

He never saw that boy again.

But Phainon still looked.

He still saved people, even as he broke them.

He still whispered soft blessings before burying his blade into another heart.

I wish there would never be a need for a Deliverer again.

That’s what Cyrene had said, years ago.

He thought of it sometimes. Not as a regret—but as a prayer. One not for him, but for the children who would come after. If any did.

And in those quiet, burning nights, he’d sit alone, tend his blade, and think:

Maybe this was the cost of being needed. Of being named.

Year 4924 of the Light Calendar.

He meets the boy again, now a man.

It shouldn’t matter. They had met once—briefly, foolishly—under the light of a dying star. But time has a way of remembering what the heart is told to forget.

Phainon sees him through the heat shimmer rising off the rocks, atop a steep cliff trail carved out by war and weather. At first, it’s just a line of crimson-helmed soldiers, their standards flapping against the dusk wind, dust trailing behind them like the ghosts of all the kingdoms they’ve conquered.

Then—

There. Riding at the head.

Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos.

The Crown Prince. The General. The Titan-slayer.

And the boy Phainon once dared to call Mydei.

His hair was longer now, sharper, running down wildly like a mane. Red still stains the ends—like the war itself has dipped its fingers into him. His frame has filled out with quiet strength, shoulders squared with years of battle and burden. The red markings have grown more elaborate, stretching

down his arms like vines of fire. Armor plates catch the sun and glint with old blood.

Phainon doesn’t let his expression shift.

He watches as the army descends, as the prince dismounts, giving orders without shouting. Soldiers move like tides around him, reverent, precise.

He’s too far to speak to.

Too high to reach.

So Phainon says nothing. He simply watches. He counts the space between them—each step, each breath, each year that’s passed. The way the earth bends under Mydei’s presence. The way the world seems to pause.

And then—

The prince looks at him.

Across the camp. Across the war. Across the silence.

Their eyes meet.

A heartbeat.

And then Mydei turns away, as if it meant nothing at all.

Phainon should’ve walked away then.

He *meant* to.

The Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos was not someone one simply spoke to—let alone challenged. Not in front of his army. Not when said army stood like carved obsidian, lined row after row in gleaming discipline. Kremnoan soldiers didn’t fidget. They didn’t murmur. They didn’t *breathe* unless ordered to.

But maybe it was the heat. Maybe it was the sharp looks he kept catching in his peripheral vision—distrust from his own men, disinterest from Mydeimos. Maybe it was how, after everything, the prince barely spared him a glance.

But mostly?

It was the smile.

That faint curl of Mydeimos's mouth—aimed at a commander, shared over some unspoken word—and Phainon felt something twitch beneath his ribs. An old fuse. A youth's temper, barely buried.

"I challenge you," he said, sudden and abrupt. "To a duel."

The shift was immediate.

A dozen Kremnoan soldiers straightened like spears, their hands drifting subtly toward hilts—though no one dared draw. Not yet.

Mydeimos turned his head slowly.

His white-blonde hair, darker now with dust and sun, moved just slightly in the wind. His gaze, when it landed on Phainon, was unreadable.

"You speak out of turn," he said.

Phainon shrugged. "Maybe. Or maybe you're just pretending not to hear me because you're afraid."

A collective, restrained inhale rolled through the Kremnoan line—silent, but *sharp*. Every soldier remained perfectly still, like marble statues forged for war.

Mydei's jaw ticked. "The Kremnoans," he said, cool and clear, "do not have a word for fear."

Phainon grinned. "Funny. You said that the last time we met."

The temperature in the air shifted, almost imperceptibly. Mydeimos studied him harder now. A memory flickered behind his eyes, there and gone.

“This is beneath me,” Mydeimos said after a long pause. “A prince does not waste time entertaining ghosts.”

“Then say no,” Phainon replied, sweetly. “Say it loud. So your *soldiers* know that as well.”

One heartbeat.

Two.

Then Mydeimos moved—just a step forward. But in that one step, every soldier behind him subtly adjusted formation. A ripple of discipline. Not a threat. A *warning*.

Phainon stood his ground.

Mydeimos regarded him. “Five minutes. No blades. No death.”

Phainon gave a cocky little bow. “You always were a little dramatic, *Mydeimos*.”

That got a visible twitch from a Kremnoan captain.

The prince’s gaze narrowed. “That name is too long for your mouth.”

Phainon smirked. “Then I’ll call you Mydei. Easier to shout when you lose.”

The duel began with no fanfare. No blaring horns or offered prayers. Only a single nod from Mydeimos, and the whisper of steel sliding from sheath as he tossed his blade to the ground.

No blades. No killing blows. Just fists, wit, and whatever the gods had given them.

It was not meant to last long.

But on the first day, when Phainon’s knuckles cracked against Mydei’s ribs and the prince stumbled only to retaliate with a sweep that sent Phainon sprawling—something shifted.

By nightfall, neither had relented.

They fought beneath the sun, between camps, with Kremnoan soldiers and Ampheran allies forming a silent, tense ring around them. It became an unspoken command not to interfere. Something sacred was unfolding.

On the second night, someone whispered from the sidelines, “They’ll kill each other.”

Phainon spat blood, laughed, and tackled Mydei into the dirt.

On the third day, the ground beneath them was torn with footprints, bloodied palms, and bruised egos. Mydeimos barely spoke, but his gaze burned each time Phainon rose again. And rise he did—each time more battered, more breathless, yet impossibly bright-eyed. Mydei never smiled, but his jabs slowed, just a beat.

On the fifth night, rain poured from the heavens like it, too, wanted to see how far they’d go. They slipped and clawed and pressed foreheads against each other mid-fight, gasping like beasts. Neither yielded.

On the sixth day, they collapsed together.

For a full hour, neither moved. Not from surrender—but because exhaustion had claimed them. And then, as if in sync, they stood again.

On the seventh day, the war paused. Orders forgotten. Spears lowered. Entire battalions watched. Mydeimos struck with the fury of ten soldiers. Phainon danced with the defiance of the stars. They bled into the sand. They grinned through bruises. They roared one another’s names.

On the ninth night, fire surrounded the sky—an omen, the priests whispered. As if the gods were watching. As if some celestial choice was being weighed. But neither one turned their eyes to the heavens.

Only to each other.

On the tenth day, they clashed one final time, fists colliding in the air, both falling back into the dirt. Chests heaving. Hands trembling. Eyes locked.

Mydei's lip bled.

Phainon's knuckles cracked.

Neither stood.

Neither won.

They simply… lay there, staring at the ceilingless sky, breathless.

When someone—his allies, maybe, or one of Mydeimos's guards—stepped forward at last, both men raised a hand without looking. *Don't.* Not yet.

Because in that shared, aching silence—no war, no title, no army, no deliverance—there was only them. Boys once. Men now.

Both undefeated. Both undone.

The air still thrummed with the memory of fists and fire when Phainon stood again, wincing as his bruised ribs protested.

His curls were a mess of sand and sweat, his jaw swollen, blood dried along his temple—but his grin? Sharp as ever.

He turned toward the Kremnoan camp, where Mydeimos now sat on a stone ledge, water trickling from the basin behind him. His chest rose and fell in heavy intervals, hand resting idly on a fresh bandage along his side. The Kremnoan guards flanked him like carved marble, unmoving.

Phainon raised a brow and stepped forward.

"I want a night with the prince," he announced, loud enough for even the heavens to hear.

Gasps.

Immediate. Scandalized. The crackle of spears shifting.

One soldier stepped forward, face twisted with fury. “You *dare*—”

But Mydeimos didn’t flinch.

Didn’t blink.

Didn’t look.

He simply lifted a single hand—fingers uncurled in a loose, downward gesture of permission.

The Kremnoans froze.

The silence afterward was thunderous.

Phainon, ever himself, gave a low, mocking bow and winked toward the flustered soldiers. “Don’t worry. I’m very gentle.”

The tent was dark as they entered, save for the flicker of oil-light from the brazier. Phainon moved with rare stillness, damp cloth pressed against Mydeimos’s temple. The prince sat shirtless, back straight, wounds bared like medals—silent, but not cold.

Phainon wiped gently, then reached up to brush a strand of pale hair from his brow.

“You’ve grown quieter,” he murmured.

“You’ve grown louder,” Mydeimos replied.

Neither smiled.

Phainon reached for a salve next, careful, fingers brushing along bruised muscle. The tension that once lived in Mydeimos’s posture was gone now, not from weakness—but trust.

Or something like it.

“You didn’t have to say yes,” Phainon said after a beat.

“I didn’t say yes to your words,” Mydei replied.

Phainon paused. “Then what?”

“To the way you looked at me. Like you’ve been waiting a long time.”

Phainon said nothing. He didn’t need to.

He just pressed the cloth back to Mydei’s brow, gentle as rain.

And stayed.

———

They had only one night. And yet, a thousand lived between them.
In every scraped knee wrapped, every shared ration, every spar that ended with grins or bruises.
The war didn’t give them time. But they made it anyway.

———

The embers of the war camp glowed low, casting flickering shadows along the cracked stone. The night was warm and unusually quiet—no distant shouting, no sword singing against steel. Just the low hum of life momentarily stilled.

Phainon walked backward along the dirt path, hands locked behind his head as he chattered, voice bright and teasing in the moonlight.

“…and I’m just saying, *maybe* if the maps weren’t rolled like a jealous ex’s love letters, we’d still have the southern ridge plan intact!”

Behind him, Mydei was silent, save for the measured sound of his boots against the earth. Silent—but listening. He always listened.

Phainon grinned, cocking a brow over his shoulder. “What, nothing? No icy quip? No righteous lecture from the Kremnoan Wall himself?”

Then it happened.

His heel caught on a jutting rock, invisible in the low light.

And he tumbled.

Forward. Fast.

And directly into Mydei.

Not just into him—*onto* him. Hands flailing, weight shifting, everything clumsy and off-kilter. His palms landed hard against bare skin, skimming over pecs before—*oh no*—

Oh no.

Phainon’s hands had landed squarely, inarguably, on Mydei’s chest.

More specifically: groping him. Full contact. Fingers curled like a lover’s grasp. He froze mid-sprawl, face mashed embarrassingly close to Mydei’s collarbone, practically inhaling him.

Time did not move.

Neither did Phainon.

Neither did Mydei.

Phainon, unblinking, thought wildly: *This is where I die. This is how it ends. The gods will strike me down. He’ll break my arms. Cyrene will laugh at my funeral.*

Mydei’s voice broke the silence like the crack of a whip.

“…Do I want to know why your hands are still there?”

Phainon blinked.

Then he jolted upright so fast it nearly gave him whiplash. He stumbled backward, brushing himself off with the frantic energy of someone who had just, with great dignity, mortified himself beyond repair.

“I didn’t mean to—! It was the—gravity—” he sputtered. “You—you’re not wearing a shirt and I panicked—”

Mydei raised a brow. Slowly.

Phainon, breathless, gathered the last of his composure and said with all the faux confidence of a man about to be sent to war:

“…For what it’s worth, you’ve got the nicest chest I’ve ever accidentally manhandled.”

Silence.

Deafening silence.

Even the wind stopped to listen.

Mydei blinked. Just once. As if unsure he’d heard correctly.

Phainon’s mind caught up to his mouth.

He panicked.

And did the most natural thing he could think of: he reached up and *flicked* Mydei’s forehead.

It made a soft, sacrilegious little thwip.

Mydei’s expression didn’t change for a heartbeat. And then—

A twitch.

A *dangerous* twitch at the corner of his mouth.

Phainon’s soul left his body.

“Oh, gods. That wasn’t—that wasn’t what I meant to do—”

He took a step back.

“Mydei.”

Another step.

“Let’s be rational.”

Another.

“I bruise like a peach.”

And then—*he ran.*

Bolted.

Into the dark like a man possessed, legs flailing, hair wild in the wind.

“Mydei, don’t chase me! I’m too young to die!” he called over his shoulder.

“You *flicked* me,” came the cold, low reply—followed by the unmistakable sound of boots hitting ground.

“You have no sense of humor!” Phainon yelped, dodging behind a tree.

“I warned you about testing Kremnoan restraint.”

“It was meant to be charming!”

“Congratulations. It was not.”

A scuffle. A thud. A yell.

Laughter. Wild, breathless laughter echoing into the quiet night. Like a storm made of starlight.

Phainon *bolted* into the forest like a wind-cursed deer, crashing through branches and low-hanging leaves, practically sprinting for his dignity.

“Stupid, stupid, *stupid*,” he hissed to himself, leaping over a fallen log. “Who *flicks* a prince? Who *gropes* a general?! Gods, my hands were right there—why am I like this?!”

He spun behind the thick trunk of an old ash tree, panting, clutching his own face. His heart was doing a military march in his chest. “Okay. Okay. He won’t come after you. He’s too noble. Too restrained. Too—”

Something rustled to his left.

He froze.

“…Please be a squirrel.”

The branches above him *creaked*.

His breath hitched. He turned his head slowly.

There, crouched like some divine punishment—or a smug cat actually—was Mydei. In the trees. *Above* him. Perfectly balanced. Perfectly silent.

Phainon had exactly 0.4 seconds to register the sight before Mydei *dropped.*

“TITAN’S ALIVE—!”

He didn’t just fall on him. He *tackled* him.

Phainon *shrieked*. A very dignified, very heroic shriek. Like a war god with a stubbed toe.

They crashed to the ground in a tangle of limbs and curses, Phainon flailing like a man trying to wrestle a hurricane, and at some point even trying to bite the other. Mydei moved fast, all trained reflex and calm violence, pinning Phainon’s wrists to the earth like it was a battlefield and he was claiming the kill.

“Stop *moving*,” Mydei growled.

“Are you trying to kill me or is this some secret royal foreplay?!”

“…What.”

Phainon, realizing how entirely doomed he was, stopped struggling—but only physically. Mentally, he was already writing his eulogy.

“Well, this is fine,” he said, flat on his back beneath a very shirtless, very intense Mydei. “This is my life now. Died doing what I loved.”

“You tried to *bite me*,” Mydei said, stunned.

“It was instinct!” Phainon protested. “Fight or flight!”

“…You bit me on the shoulder.”

“I was panicking!”

Mydei stared down at him, completely silent.

Phainon, ever the survivalist, looked directly into the abyss and threw himself off the ledge. Again.

“You know,” he said, voice dropping into something that might’ve been sultry if he wasn’t also covered in twigs and dirt, “if you wanted to pin me down, all you had to do was ask, *Mydei*.”

Mydei blinked.

Twice.

Slowly.

Like he’d just suffered a minor stroke.

Then—*genuine concern* flashed across his face. “Are you… are you unwell?”

“I—” Phainon hesitated.

“…No?”

Another blink.

Then, as if the entire weight of the interaction was finally, *finally* hitting him, Mydei released a single, long breath through his nose, got off him, and stood—dignity untouched. Phainon, on the other hand, rolled onto his side and groaned into the dirt.

“Do not move,” Mydei said, brushing twigs from his waist. “I’m going to get a physician.”

“For what?”

“To see if you’ve had a brain injury.”

“Oh *come on*—”

Phainon’s voice dissolved into a soft laugh, but it didn’t linger long. The sound barely echoed before it fell flat into the quiet between them.

The silence after felt heavier than before, like even the air had remembered where they were. The camp around them creaked faintly with the weight of armor set aside for the night. Somewhere in the distance, a soldier murmured in his sleep. Someone turned over in the grass.

And suddenly in no time, the crackling of the fire was the loudest thing in the world.

Phainon lowered his gaze, fingers brushing the dirt.

Mydei didn’t say anything. He only resumed sharpening the blade he didn’t need to sharpen.

“…Do you ever think about who you’d be if you weren’t a prince?” Phainon asked one day. Not out of harm. Not to provoke. Just—curious.

Mydei didn’t look up at first. His fingers stilled at the blade’s edge. Then, without glancing over, he said:

“I’d run a café.”

Phainon blinked. “A café?”

“Somewhere quiet,” Mydei said, still not looking at him. “Small. No sign out front. No one talks unless they need to. I’d open at dawn. Close by dusk.”

“You hate people.”

“I’d make an exception for one.”

Phainon smiled, slow and surprised. The kind that started in his chest and curled at the corners of his mouth without permission.

He reached for a twig and poked at the fire, pushing ash around in small, thoughtful circles. The heat bit at his fingers. Still, he didn’t move them.

“You’d hate me as a regular.”

“Why’s that?”

“I’d order something ridiculous. Every time. Ask for seven sugars. Make you spell my name wrong on the cup.”

“You’d do it on purpose.”

“Obviously.”

Finally, Mydei looked over. His expression wasn’t amused, not exactly. But it was softer than it had been before. Tired, in a way that had nothing to do with battle.

“I think I’d still let you in,” he said.

Phainon didn’t respond right away. He just nodded, barely perceptible, like that truth was too delicate to acknowledge out loud.

The fire crackled again.

Then, quietly—almost to himself—Mydei added, “You’d complain about the bitter coffee every morning.”

Phainon’s voice was a murmur, half-laugh, half-thought. “And you’d act like you didn’t care. But the next day, it’d be sweeter.”

They sat like that for a while. Not as a soldier and a prince. Not as a Deliverer and future King. Just two men, in a war they didn’t ask for, sharing the warmth of a fire neither wanted to end.

Somewhere in the dark, someone coughed. A hawk shrieked from far off, circling.

Still, neither of them moved.

And the fire burned on.

Time moved differently at the edge of a war.

Some nights blurred together. Some never left.

Phainon had long lost track of how many days they’d been stationed near the ruins of a city that didn’t even have a name anymore. The scent of ash was always in the air, no matter which way the wind blew. The moon, when it appeared, hung low and watchful—like it too had seen too much.

They trained in the mornings. Fought in the afternoons. And when they weren’t bleeding or running, they were teaching.

“Like this,” Mydei said, hands firm over Phainon’s as he adjusted the hilt of a short, wicked Kremnoan blade. “You’re still holding it like an Elysian priest holds incense.”

“That’s because I’m holy and delicate,” Phainon replied, grinning through the sting in his wrists.

Mydei rolled his eyes and stepped back. “You’re going to lose your fingers.”

“Well if I do, I’ll recite epics with my teeth.” Phainon turned the blade over, inspecting it. “Did you know there’s a whole poem in the Northern archives about a man who used his nose as a weapon?”

“Stop speaking.”

“I’m just saying, there’s historical precedent.”

They moved like this for a while—blade, breath, banter. A strange ritual of rhythm and repetition. Mydei corrected. Phainon complained. And somewhere in the middle of all of it, they forgot the silence that usually sat between men like them.

After training, they sat beneath the broken arch of a shattered temple. The stone above them was cracked, but still held weight. Like them.

Phainon wiped sweat from his brow, leaning back on his palms, eyes trailing the clouds.

“You know,” he said, “I’m starting to wonder if the Kremnoans have any words in their language at all.”

Mydei, sipping from a waterskin, glanced at him sidelong. “What?”

“I’m serious. You keep saying ‘the Kremnoans don’t have a word for this’ and ‘the Kremnoans don’t say that’—I’m starting to think your whole dictionary is just one long pause.”

Mydei didn’t answer immediately. For once, he didn’t even smirk. His gaze drifted to the horizon, sharp and far-off, like he was looking for something no one else could see.

Then, after a beat, he said it—almost to himself.

“…Haikas.”

Phainon blinked. “So there *are* words?”

No answer.

“What’s that mean?” Phainon leaned forward, nudging Mydei’s knee with his own. “Come on. Teach me something.”

But Mydei didn’t explain. Just looked at him with that same unreadable expression—like Phainon was some starless constellation only he could trace.

And then, with a strange finality in his voice, Mydei said, “Deliverer…If there's a chance in the next life, you should come visit my library.”

Phainon’s grin softened. He tilted his head.

“…Why not this one?”

Mydei didn’t answer.

Far in the distance, smoke curled like an omen from the battlefield. Their break would end soon.

Phainon wanted to say something else. Anything. But all he could do was sit there, the silence stretching like a tether between them, fraying at the edges.

He didn’t know why it hurt.

He didn’t know why it felt like goodbye.

He didn’t know what *Haikas* meant.

But he knew how Mydei said it.

And somehow, that was worse.

———

Χαϊκάς
Haikas
Scoundrel
But in the mouth of a Kremnoan prince, it means:
The one I let stay too long. The one I never asked to leave

———

It was another city. Another city that had no name anymore.

Its title, once carved into obsidian tablets and sung in the high courts of kings, has been lost to fire. All that remains are its ribs—arches of fallen temples, scorched avenues where the wind sifts through bone-colored dust.

The Titans came through like a prophecy fulfilled. Like wrath wearing a crown.

Phainon picks his way over rubble, the soles of his boots cracking fragments of mosaic beneath them. Golds and blues, hints of frescoes that used to mean something. The air is thick with the scent of scorched cedar and stone still bleeding heat. Somewhere, a broken lyre string hums in the wind, trapped between two shattered columns.

He sees Mydei long before he reaches him.

The prince stands with his back turned, gaze lifted toward what once must’ve been a shrine. He’s motionless, framed by ruin like a figure painted into myth. The light catches on the blood soaked into his ribs, stark against the pale gleam of his skin. It’s not mortal blood—Phainon knows that—but his chest still clenches at the sight.

“Mydei,” Phainon calls softly.

It feels wrong to speak here.

Mydei doesn’t turn around. His voice rises like smoke from embers, low and steady.

“You asked me once what I’d do… if I weren’t a prince.”

Phainon slows.

It takes him a moment to place when he asked that.

Then, quieter, “What about you?”

Phainon opens his mouth to respond, but nothing comes out.

What would he do, if he weren’t this?

If he weren’t the Deliverer?

If the gods hadn’t spun that title from starlight and burdened and pressed it’s future into his bones?

His mind flickers through the answers that should be easy—peace, purpose, his village, the stars—but they don’t land. They don’t feel true.

He sees, instead, Mydei brushing flour from his face. Mydei’s jaw slack with sleep in a sunlit room. Mydei with a sword at his side, but soft behind the eyes.

He sees a life he never planned to want.

“I don’t know,” he whispers.

This time, Mydei turns.

His gaze sweeps over Phainon’s face like he’s searching for something. His mouth twitches at the corner—an almost smile.

There’s a long pause.

Then Mydei speaks again, voice low and not quite steady.

“If it’s ever me,” he says, “strike the tenth thoracic vertebra.”

The words slip into the space between them like a knife set carefully on a table. Not a threat nor a plea.

Just truth, laid bare.

Phainon doesn’t react.

He doesn’t gasp or protest or fall to his knees in horror. He only stares. Eyes unreadable. Mouth parting like he might say something, but the words crumble before they reach air.

Mydei watches him. He’s already turning away when he adds, so softly Phainon almost misses it:

“If it happens,” he says, “if it ever happens—”

He exhales, slow and steady.

“Let it be in your arms.”

It isn’t a confession. It’s a wish left half-made in the dust.

Phainon doesn’t move.

He just watches the light catch in Mydei’s lashes as he turns away again, the moment folding into the bones of the city around them.

———

Θα πεθάνω στα χέρια σου.
I will die in your arms.
If not from your blade, then from the weight of never saying I loved you.

———

Year 4926 of the Light Calendar.
The night before the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos and his

Detachment departed for their ancestral stronghold—where thrones are forged in the bones of kings and blood begets legacy.

No fanfare echoed through the outpost that evening. Only the rustle of olive branches, the flicker of oil lamps, and the distant calls of soldiers laughing like boys before they remembered they were weapons.

Phainon did not have to knock.

The guards standing outside Mydeimos' private quarters merely stepped aside, no longer asking questions. They had long grown used to his presence. Besides, they had seen the way the Crown Prince of Strife looked at Phainon when he thought no one else was watching.

The door opened with a hush.

Inside, the chamber was dim, lit only by the warm breath of a single hanging lamp. There were maps rolled on the table, an untouched cup of water, and a figure at the window.

Phainon paused in the threshold.

And then—his breath caught.

Mydeimos stood alone, arms folded loosely behind his back, head turned slightly toward the window, though not to look through it. No—his gaze had drifted somewhere far beyond the stars, further than memory, perhaps into prophecy. The light cast across his profile sharpened the high bridge of his nose, the strong line of his jaw. His hair, grown longer now, curled just beneath his ears, unbound for once. It made him look younger. Or lonelier.

Like the final verse of a love poem left unsung.

O Kephale—he is beautiful, Phainon thought. *And he is so very alone.*

He moved without a sound, shedding the mantle of command that always clung to his shoulders when he walked among the war-bound. Now he was just Phainon—just a man who had watched the world burn and found something worth keeping in its ashes.

He approached slowly. Mydei didn’t turn. Not even when Phainon sat beside him, leaving a breath of space between them.

Stillness.

Then—Phainon spoke first. Quietly.

“I spoke to Krateros.”

A pause. The prince said nothing. The only reply was the rise and fall of his breath. Steady, dignified. But not indifferent.

Phainon glanced sideways.

Even in silence, he could read the thoughts that lived in Mydei’s stillness.

The way one hand remained clenched, nails barely imprinting his palm—a ritual of control. The faint line between his brows that appeared when he was lost in thought. His chest rose in perfect rhythm, like a trained march, and yet… something in his posture betrayed exhaustion.

Phainon leaned in, tilting his head slightly, just enough for his temple to rest against Mydei’s.

The prince did not flinch. Instead, he let out the smallest exhale—like the tension in his body had been waiting for this exact contact to slip away.

They remained like that, pressed shoulder to shoulder. No declarations. No begging him to stay. Just together with shared breath.

Phainon didn’t need to look down to find his hand—he simply reached out, and Mydei met him halfway. Fingers laced together, as if they had always known how to find each other.

No words were spoken.

But in that silence, there was everything:

A crown. A war. A choice. A night that would not come again.

And two men sitting beside one another like dusk and dawn, never meant to meet, and yet still touching in the breath between stars.

Later that night when the torches burned lower than usual and the outpost had gone quiet with the hush of those bracing for departure, Phainon returned to Mydei's chambers once again.

The guards didn't glance his way this time.

Inside, it was warm. Mydei had extinguished all but one lantern, its glow painting gold across the stone walls and soft shadow over his shoulders. He sat at the edge of the bed, hands resting loosely on his knees, as if he were trying to memorize how stillness felt before stepping into war.

Phainon closed the door behind him, slowly.

Neither of them said anything at first.

Mydei looked up—and whatever tension remained in his face eased at the sight of him. Just barely. Just enough for Phainon to notice the way his shoulders dipped, the tightness around his mouth softening.

"You should sleep," Phainon said gently.

"I will," Mydei replied, voice a quiet thing.

They didn't speak again as Phainon approached, only met one another halfway. Fingers brushing. Eyes catching. Breath syncing.

And then—

Their foreheads touched.

Phainon's hand cradled the back of Mydei's neck, and Mydei's eyes fluttered closed, as if the world was loud and this—this was silence.

"Wait for me," Mydei whispered, so close their lips almost met.

Phainon pressed closer. His hand splayed over Mydei’s heart, steady and sure.

“I’d wait,” he murmured, “until the stars forget their names.”

What followed wasn’t hurried.

Phainon helped him undress, careful and quiet, like reverence was sewn into every movement. He let his hands linger longer than needed—not out of lust, but devotion.

There were bandages on Mydei’s ribs. Dried blood. Faint bruises that the divine body could not quite hide. Phainon removed the wrappings slowly, brushing his fingers over the worst of it, and Mydei leaned into his touch.

He didn’t flinch. He never did.

But when Phainon knelt between his knees and pressed a kiss to his ribs, just beneath the edge of his heart, Mydei’s hand found his shoulder and held it.

Not to guide him. Only to ground himself.

When they came together, it was with the gentleness of those who had learned not to rush things worth keeping. Phainon’s hands never left him—never lost their place. They mapped him like a scripture, like a constellation too sacred to speak aloud.

He touched Mydei as if to memorize him. As if to leave behind something no blade could unmake.

And when he leaned over him, when his mouth traced the length of his spine—he reached the point just between his shoulder blades, where the 10th vertebra lay in quiet threat.

Phainon stilled.

Then, slowly, deliberately, he kissed it. Once.

The ghost of a smile curved Mydei’s lips.

“That’s not how you kill me,” he murmured.

“I know,” Phainon said. He pressed another kiss to the spot, softer this time. “I’m not trying to.”

They moved like ocean and tide after that—pulling into each other, again and again, as if trying to delay dawn with their bodies alone.

And when it was over—when they lay tangled together in quiet—

Mydei’s voice broke through the dark, faint as a prayer:

“I love you, as if the world aches when you are not beside me.”

Phainon didn’t speak at first.

He only cupped Mydei’s jaw, thumb brushing along the line of his cheek. His smile was tired. Soft.

“If there is a next life…” he whispered, “come back to me.”

Mydei’s eyes fluttered open. “Even if I’m a stranger?”

“I’ll know you,” Phainon said. “Even in silence.”

Their fingers intertwined again.

Outside, the stars wheeled overhead—ancient, watchful, waiting.

The prince slept for the last time beside the only man who had ever looked at him and seen not a weapon, not a prince, but a person.

The Son of Gorgo departed before sunrise.

Phainon hadn’t watched him go. Not directly.

But he’d heard the sound of hooves. Of banners raised. Of armor being fastened over linen in the half-light.

And he’d known, by the time the wind shifted, that Mydei was already gone.

The Kremnoan Detachment rode like a storm breaking away from itself.

They did not look back.

Not even him.

A month had passed since Mydei left, and with him, the rhythm of something Phainon hadn’t known he was clinging to.

The war had not ended, but it had shifted—moved from flame to embers, the kind that still scorched if touched, but no longer demanded the whole of the sky. Cities murmured in passing about a siege in the east, about red standards raised above shattered stone. The tales came wrapped in awe and smoke: a prince crowned not with ceremony, but conquest. A son who left no eulogy for the father he unseated—only silence, and a vow spoken through blood.

When permission came for Phainon to return home, it arrived without flourish. A folded note. A single name. A word that might have meant respite.

They called it *rest*.

As if anyone could rest with half their soul on the other side of the continent. As if the ache of war could be soothed by the scent of old cedar or the hush of mountain air. As if anything had made sense after the moment Mydei turned away and didn’t look back.

Phainon rode alone through the highlands, past ghost towns and overgrown temples. The thaw had begun; rivers now moved with a low murmur instead

of the brittle silence of winter. Birds returned in stuttering flocks, uncertain of the season.

The skies were clear. The roads soft beneath the hooves. His uniform bore no sigils now, only dust and the weight of memory. His hair had grown longer than regulation. Tied low at his nape, it brushed against the collar of his coat whenever the wind stirred.

Still, nothing reached him.

Not the sun against his face. Not the prayers etched into roadside altars. Not even the shoulder that throbbed beneath its bandage, the slow reminder of a wound that hadn’t fully closed.

Everything around him moved with a sort of hush—as if the world itself had gone quiet the day Mydei left, and was still figuring out how to speak again.

And Mydei’s voice—loud, commanding, deeply patient—still echoed in the places silence couldn’t fill.

But never in words.

Only the absence of them.

It was near dusk on the third day of his travel when Phainon came upon it.

Tucked between the crumbled stone of an unnamed village and the moss-covered remnants of a temple, the fountain stood like a relic from a story no one told anymore. The basin was chipped, veined with time, but the water still ran—clear, slow, deliberate.

He dismounted with a quiet breath. The road behind him was long and dust-covered. The one ahead even longer.

No birdsong. No voices. Just the hush of wind threading through old branches.

They used to say this fountain could show you what your heart yearned for most.

A child’s tale, surely. A myth meant to distract from hunger and grief.

Still—he stepped forward.

The water barely stirred. No shimmer, no illusion. Only his own reflection, sun-washed and weary, staring back at him. His face had changed. Eyes deeper set. Mouth quieter.

But then—something shifted. Not in the surface.

In him.

A memory, sudden and sharp, bloomed behind his eyes.

Not a face. A presence.

The feel of Mydei’s hand brushing against his in passing. The way he stood, steady as a mountain, yet looked at Phainon like he was the only thing in motion. The press of silence between them before a battle, heavy with everything they never said.

Phainon swallowed hard.

His chest ached, sudden and full, like he’d been holding something in for far too long.

He knelt.

Dipped his fingers into the water. Cold. Real.

And then—almost without meaning to—he recited the line in his head. A fragment from an old epic, worn at the edges, clung to over years like a secret prayer:

To gaze into his eyes was to touch the divine—
one glance, and I forgot my name.

He sat there a while longer.

Not waiting. Not praying.

Just remembering what it felt like to be seen.

And in that quiet, he didn’t look for a miracle or a blessing.

He only hoped Mydei had found a place to rest.

Chapter End Notes

> No cause I’m HUSTLING to finish this to get to the next chapter of Paper Cuts and Pyres and then write the rockstar au x idol outline I have
>
> I literally have no idea what to put in the summary so if anyone has ideas TELL ME PLZZZZZ, next chapter is probably gonna be out today or tomorrow since most of it is already written (I mean it’s the smut chapter and I wrote that before anything else so😭) but I’m adding extra details. So uhhh what do we think so far though????

Chapter 2: Threshold

Chapter Summary

> After five years of waiting, Phainon was ready to give up—until the god he was meant to surrender to turned out to be his not-boyfriend, who he'd been waiting for half a decade. Talk about bad timing

Chapter Notes

> Ok wtf, sorry yall a migraine knocked me out cold, hence the late update😭 Abd I kept pushing through it so uhhh, IT GOT WORSE Anyway I'm all better now😍 Yeah so the chapter got WAYYY too long so I'm splitting it into 2, so no smut till the next one😔
>
> Anyway, enjoy <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

O goddess of Love, grant me wings,
to reach the one I cannot forget.
If it is sacrifice, let it be me.
If it is pain, let love burn within me.

Let me carry his name in silence.
Let me ache where he once touched me.
And if he returns not by prayer or fate,
then let me wait—for waiting is its own kind of worship.

Aedes Elysiae bloomed for him that night.

The city's stones gleamed beneath thousands of torches, their golden light turning marble red as flame. Banners swept down from archways like wings; flowers were thrown until the ground bloomed with them, riotous

and bright. Music climbed from the plazas in great spirals of sound—lyres, flutes, the chant of voices all rising in his name.

Phainon returned beneath torchlight. Laurel on his head, blood on his cloak. A conquering son. A crowned victor.

They sang of his blade. Of the night siege at Callidora. Of the general who fell to his knees before him. Of the godless prince who did not flinch when death passed over him thrice.

And Phainon smiled, because it was expected. He lifted a hand to the crowd, to the temple priests, to the senators with their marble smiles. He walked between colonnades draped in gold-threaded cloth, bowed his head when the children scattered petals at his feet.

But it was like breathing through linen.

Beneath the wreath on his brow, he felt nothing. The cheers came muffled, like water closing over his ears. Every face blurred at the edges, every voice too loud and too far. His boots rang out over stone, but the sound was wrong. Off. Hollow. As if the ground itself waited for a different set of footsteps.

Where there should have been a voice—steady, low, warm as flame—there was silence.

Where there should have been eyes—dark, iron-rich, laughing at him when no one else dared—there was shadow.

He was led to the highest hall, draped in silk, offered goblets heavy with wine and hands eager to unlace the armor from his shoulders. But he shook them off with a smile soft enough to hide the ache. The celebration swelled around him, and he stood in the center like a ghost haunting his own triumph.

That night, Aedes Elysiae crowned its hero.

But in the room carved from ivory and myth, Phainon did not sleep.

He lay wrapped in silk that smelled of myrrh, hearing the village—now small city practically—cry his name through the open windows, and thought only of a hand that no longer reached for his.

He touched the pillow beside him.

Still cold.

Still empty.

The songs outside swelled—praises of valor, of glory, of a name he no longer recognized. A name that meant nothing when spoken by strangers.

Glory, he thought distantly, *is a chorus sung too late.*

Sleep took him like a tide, not with peace but with gravity—and in the dark, it did not give him dreams of triumph, nor even of battle.

Only a quiet grove. A boy with storm-lit eyes. Peeling fruit with a dull knife, juice slipping down his wrist. Saying nothing. Only looking.

Looking at him like he already knew—

That Phainon would carry him through every silence that followed.

While the city roared with praise, but Phainon dreamt of peace.

Not the peace of aftermaths or sacred halls—but a gentler hush, the kind that settles when a life is fully lived and nothing must be earned anymore.

In the dream, they were not princes or soldiers or offerings to gods. They were two men beneath a fig tree, sun-warmed and barefoot, with nothing to protect and no one to bury.

The villa was small—whitewashed stone, a single clay jar on the windowsill, a thin sheet hanging like a veil in the breeze. Phainon smelled citrus and the sweet, damp scent of earth. Somewhere, someone’s goat bleated. A bee nosed lazily at an open pomegranate.

Mydei was in the garden, sleeves rolled to the elbow, skin kissed golden by a life lived in light. He knelt to gather herbs, humming something tuneless, and when he looked up, his smile was as quiet as a prayer.

“You woke late,” he said. “I nearly ate all the olives myself.”

Phainon stepped barefoot into the dirt. The ground was warm. “Liar,” he said, fondly.

Mydei stood and offered him a slice of bread. He had torn it unevenly, and the fig jam ran down one wrist. Phainon took it anyway, licking the sweetness from his thumb as their shoulders touched.

There was no urgency. No war beyond the garden wall. Only the weight of Mydei’s head resting lightly on his shoulder as they sat on the steps, watching the wind rustle through the olive trees.

They spoke little. But they didn’t need words.

Mydei reached over to braid a stray lock of Phainon’s hair, fingers slow and clumsy. “Stay still,” he murmured.

“I am,” Phainon lied, grinning despite himself. “You’re just bad at this.”

“I should arrest you for treason,” Mydei muttered. But he was smiling too.

The sun dipped lower. Somewhere, water trickled. They sat like that until the light turned honeyed and long shadows fell over the courtyard.

And when Mydei leaned in to kiss him—softly, like the world was new and they had all the time it could offer—Phainon tasted peace.

In the dream, he believed it could last.

And in the dream, Phainon thought: *If there is a heaven, let it be this.*

But dreams are cruel things.

The light fractured. The fig tree trembled like it was being pulled away.

And then—

He woke.

Not violently, not with a cry—but slowly, like surfacing from something too warm to leave. His body was still, but his hand reached before his mind caught up, fingers brushing the empty space beside him. Only sheets. Only a different kind of silence.

The light outside still flickered, the revelry faint now, distant. He heard laughter, a lyre, the murmur of wine being poured—but it felt like listening through water, far away from where he lay.

Phainon turned his face into the pillow and exhaled, as if trying to bury the ache back into the dream.

There was no one to speak to, and nothing left to say.

So he said nothing.

He simply lay there, eyes open in the dark, heart full of something that could not be named—only carried.

———

Άσε με να θυμάμαι.
Let me remember.
Even if it ruins me. Even if it’s all I have left.

———

The air in Olythia was gentler than in Aedes Elysiae—salt-touched and warm, thick with hyacinth and roasted honey almonds from the open stalls. Evening had softened the edges of the city. Lanterns bloomed along archways like low-hung stars. The marble streets were crowded, but not hurried. Lovers strolled. Merchants laughed. Somewhere, a flute trilled through the hush like a bird that had stayed too long in summer.

Phainon walked quietly beside Cyrene, the noise of the crowd passing around them like water around stone. She matched his steps without thinking—always had—and now and then their arms brushed. Neither spoke.

It had been months since his return. Time enough for the bruises to fade, for his gait to lose its limp, for the laurel-wreathed songs to cease echoing through the streets. Time enough to wear clean tunics and sit in strategy rooms again, to speak of peace as if he believed in it. Time enough for the ache to sink deeper, turn quieter.

Cyrene had been a constant. She was there in the silences, in the rough mornings when the sunlight felt too sharp, and in the evenings when he wandered too far from the dinner table. She never asked for the details of what he had lost—never pressed—but her presence said: *I saw it. I still see you.*

Now she glanced at him out of the corner of her eye, expression unreadable. They were nearing the edge of the forum, where a statue rose tall in the firelit dark—a figure carved in dark stone, proud and solemn. A Kremnoan warrior-prince, the plaque read, though the name had faded with time.

Cyrene slowed, but Phainon had already stopped.

He stood before the statue, his posture still, his gaze lifted to the chiseled face of the warrior-prince. The torchlight danced across his features, tracing the line of his jaw and the hollow beneath his chin. There was a stillness in him, something vast and silent, but not of grief. No, this was a quiet that lived in memories—longing, perhaps, or something else, buried deeper than the battle he had fought.

Cyrene said nothing. She only watched him, the soft murmur of the evening filling the spaces between them, while the world beyond seemed to hold its breath.

She didn’t speak, not at first.

The quiet between them wasn’t awkward. Just waiting.

Cyrene stepped closer, hands tucked behind her back, eyes on the same statue he stared through. “You always stop here.”

Phainon gave a vague nod. “It’s quiet.”

“That’s not why.”

A flick of a smile tugged at the corner of his mouth. “No,” he said. “It’s not.”

She glanced at him, her voice gentle but easy, like someone nudging a sleeping dog. “Who does he remind you of?”

Phainon tilted his head. “No one important.”

Cyrene arched a brow. “Mm.”

A pause. The sound of a lyre from somewhere in the city filtered through the warm night.

“He used to stand like that,” Phainon said, after a while. “Like nothing could touch him. Like if you asked, he’d deny ever carrying any weight on his back.”

“He sounds annoying.”

“He was.” A real smile now—small, crooked, reluctant. “We had this running thing. First one to spot a hawk overhead. First to climb the wall. First to find a fig sweet enough to eat. Stupid stuff.”

“Let me guess. You won?”

“I cheated.”

Cyrene huffed a quiet laugh. “You? Never.”

“I thought he didn’t know. But then one day he spit a fig seed at me and said I was the worst liar he’d ever met.”

She looked at him sidelong. “And you let him say that?”

“I let him say a lot of things.”

He shifted then, gaze dropping from the statue to the stones at their feet. The torchlight etched his features in bronze and shadow. And whatever he saw in the gaps between words, it wasn’t Olythia.

“It was easier then,” he murmured. “He’d argue, I’d let him win. He’d accuse me of pitying him. I’d pretend not to hear it.”

“Sounds like love.”

Phainon didn’t answer.

But his silence agreed.

Phainon didn’t move. The torchlight flickered across his face, and the square behind them grew quieter, as if the night had leaned in to listen.

“I’d die for him,” he said softly.

The words weren’t meant for her. Just spoken aloud. Like they’d been circling in his chest too long, and finally found the shape of breath.

Cyrene didn’t answer. She knew better. She only watched him.

He blinked once, slow. “Kill for him,” he added, like it was nothing. Like it was truth. Like he’d already done it.

He looked at the statue again, gaze steady, quiet. Reverent, almost. As if the ancient warrior carved from stone had known something he now understood too late. As if the eyes of that faceless prince had seen his own kind of ruin and chosen not to speak of it.

And in that moment, something softened in Cyrene’s chest. She looked at Phainon—not the hero they’d dressed in laurel, not the general or the golden son of Aedes Elysiae—but the boy who had learned to carry his own silences.

He looked at that statue like it hung the stars themselves.

And Cyrene, who had never particularly been a devotee, found herself whispering a prayer, so faintly that not even the wind could carry it:

Mnestia, grant them an ending that is not a tragedy.

———

Seasons shifted, but not the weight.
The hours thinned, the silence did not.
He did not pray for answers—
only that the ache might come with less teeth.

———

They sent him to Okhema at winter’s edge, when the sky turned pale as bone and frost crept into the veins of the olive trees. The summons had come draped in formality—wax seals and gilded phrasing, all dressed in ceremony. A gesture of goodwill, they called it. A chance to honor peace.

He hadn’t argued.

Okhema stood high above the coast, carved in marble and shadow. The wind there smelled of incense and aged scrolls. Choirs sang from rooftop sanctuaries, their voices drifting down like smoke. Copper bells chimed above the shops, and the streets glimmered faintly with scattered petals and ash.

It was beautiful. It was suffocating.

Phainon sat alone in the quiet of the guest chamber, the kind reserved for dignitaries and pilgrims too worn by travel to care for opulence. A bowl of fruit rested beside him on a low cedar table, untouched. His fingers toyed with the stem of a prune, turning it once, then again, before placing it back exactly where it had been.

His gaze drifted to the courtyard beyond. Ivy curled along the colonnade. The scent of lemon leaves mingled with the faint aroma of burning incense. Somewhere below, a stringed instrument played, slow and meandering—someone practicing, not performing.

He wasn't thinking, not really. His body had moved through the rites, the formalities, the greetings. He had bowed when expected, spoken when prompted. But now, in this hush between obligations, there was nothing. No sorrow. No peace. Just the slow unfurling of time, the kind that made it easy to forget whether you were meant to speak or breathe.

Then—

a shift in the air. A presence, not loud but unmistakable.

She entered like she belonged to the silence.

Tall, with sun-gilded hair cropped close to her head and eyes the color of deep tidepools. Her features were even, deliberate, framed by soft waves that curled just beneath her jaw. She wore a sleeveless gown of unbroken white, the fabric clean and crisp, pinned with delicate gold at her shoulders and traced with threads that shimmered faintly in the light.

Nothing about her arrival was loud. She didn't speak. She didn't need to.

Phainon looked up, not startled—only still.

It was not divinity that announced her, nor any thunder in the sky.

It was the kind of presence that stilled the world around it.

The kind that felt like being seen by someone who already knew everything about you and your life.

Phainon didn't rise. He only inclined his head, a quiet nod of acknowledgment—respectful, nothing more.

Aglaea didn't seem to mind. She stepped further into the room, the hem of her gown whispering against marble. She glanced toward the open shutters,

as if noting the angle of the light. As if she had time to spare.

Neither of them spoke right away.

Outside, the slow tune on the lyre faded into a pause. A bird called once, then fell silent.

Finally, Aglaea's voice broke the stillness—not loud, not soft, but steady. It felt like something woven, not spoken.

"You look well, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae."

He exhaled a quiet breath, and a corner of his mouth lifted in something not quite a smile. "I've heard worse lies."

Aglaea didn't laugh, but her expression warmed just slightly. "You've kept the years well, then, if even the truth sounds like flattery."

A pause.

He glanced toward the shuttered light. "It's quieter here."

"Okhema is a city of breath," she said. "It inhales the world's noise and exhales stillness."

He gave a small nod, the kind you make when you don't know what to say —or when what you want to say has no place in words.

"I'm told your offering was accepted with honors," she continued, settling across from him with the grace of someone who had never once stumbled. "The holy fires burned high this season. It is rare they do."

Phainon studied her, unsure whether it was a courtesy or a message.

He said nothing.

Aglaea tilted her head slightly, as though observing the spaces between what he didn't say. Her gaze was not piercing, but it was patient.

“It is good,” she said at last, “to have silence when one needs it. And someone to share it with, when it becomes too heavy.”

He looked at her then. Really looked.

And then, he braced himself for the inevitable.

Aglaea did not touch her wine.

She waited until the silence had folded neatly between them again, until the last flicker of firelight curved in her eyes. Then:

“Let’s not dance around it, Phainon.”

His gaze sharpened, but he didn’t interrupt.

“You are Chrysos-born. Your bloodline was forged in fire and salt. You are heir to the old vow.” Her voice held no malice. No urgency. Only grace and finality. “It is time you joined the Flame Chase Journey.”

Phainon didn’t move.

The room held its breath.

Then, quietly: “You speak of destiny like it’s holy.” He looked past her, toward the window, where twilight brushed gold across the clouds. “But I’ve known something more sacred than prophecy.”

He didn’t name it. He didn’t need to.

Aglaea did not press. She studied him in that long divine silence that could level greater men than him. Her expression never shifted, not with pity, not with surprise.

“The threads are already woven,” she said softly. “I only guide the loom.”

Something faltered behind his eyes, just for a moment.

Still, she did not soften.

The weight of centuries sat gently in her bearing—elegant, weary. She was the demigod of romance, yes, but romance was not love. Romance was ritual. Story. Sacrifice. She had seen enough of it to know what it cost.

But even then, something flickered in her gaze. A breath of gentleness, faint and vanishing as perfume in wind.

“There are some threads,” she said in the end, “even I would not cut.”

Silence again.

Then, finally, she stood.

“Very well,” she said, her voice light, distant. “The wheel does not mind turning slowly. Some fires choose to smolder before they rise.”

She did not say how long.

She didn’t have to.

And when she left—golden and gleaming, like sunlight receding behind temple doors—Phainon remained alone in the dim hush of the sanctum, hands resting on his knees, heart locked beneath too many names.

He did not know, then, what her silence had meant.

He did not know it would be five years.

———

Λήθη.
Lethe.
To forget. To be forgotten.To set a memory down like a blade—without knowing if you will ever pick it up again.

———

Year 4927 of the Light Calendar

He said it was for diplomacy.

That was the official reason, spoken over tea to bored senators and scribes. “I need to understand the cultural framing of their politics,” he said, tapping the table like it mattered. “Kremnos doesn’t waste breath—every word is a weapon or a vow.”

They nodded approvingly. Another tool for the golden heir. Another flourish on the record of the future Chrysos Heir.

The truth was: Phainon had begun to miss the sound of bluntness. He missed sentences that cut straight through, even when they hurt. He missed sparring without sentiment—until it bled sentiment. He missed being told he was wrong without softness, and being seen through without fear.

He missed—though he wouldn’t admit it then—a way of speaking that said: *I don’t care if you understand. I’ll show you, if you can stand it.*

So he hired a linguist. An elderly scholar who specialized in Kremnoan dialects and had no time for flattery. Their lessons were quiet, methodical. Scrolls in the morning, dictation over wine, syntax scribbled in the margins of military drafts. He wrote things phonetically at first, filling the air with sharp syllables that felt too clean in his mouth.

The early lessons were all humor.

“They have five different terms for betrayal, but not a single word for *please*,” he said to Cyrene once, amused.

She smiled, a rare smirk really. “You ever think that says more about them than the war reports did?”

“They’re honest,” he replied. “Even their lies wear armor.”

He laughed over vocabulary—how their version of *flirting* was often indistinguishable from threats of honorable combat. How one phrase translated loosely to: *If you touch my armor again, I will make you marry me*. He began a tally of words with double meanings: *shield* could mean

protection or *obstacle*, depending on the intonation. *Strike* could be an act of violence or devotion. *Oath* always meant both.

He carried a small leather notebook for his studies. At first, it was filled with grammar rules and root stems. Then, it began to gather other things.

Phrases. Half-translations. Lines he didn't want to forget.

Not *love*, exactly. That word didn't exist in the way he knew it. But he found the traces of it in other forms. In compound verbs and honor-bound constructions that said things like:

He is the one I let strike first.

I would fall on my sword before I let him go hungry.

My back is yours. Die well if I cannot protect it.

They didn't use the word *stay*. But they had three different ways to say die *beside me.* They didn't say *I miss you*, but they said *I remember the sound of your footsteps when I close my eyes.*

There was a phrase for *the last touch before war.*

Another for *I will carry the name you gave me until my bones forget it.*

Even *sorry* was poetic. Brutal. It translated more closely *to I failed to die before the damage was done.*

Phainon stopped joking after that.

He kept studying. But slower now. With focus.

Some nights, he sat by the oil lamp and traced the words with his finger, saying them under his breath—not as lessons, but as an orison. As if saying them in another tongue might somehow carry the weight of what he could never say in his own.

He told himself it was for strategy. To understand the language of conflict.

But sometimes—just sometimes—he would pause at the edge of a phrase, and remember a voice. Dry, unimpressed. A glint of lightning behind the eyes. That smirk after a loss. The easy way his name—his title—had once been said without ceremony, without fear. Like it was something known.

And he would find himself writing the same line again, even when he didn't need it:

I survived. And it would've meant more, if you had seen it.

———

Λόγια
Words, but more than speech.
The things one says to mean something else. A name dressed in metaphor. A toast laced with memory.

———

Year 4928 of the Light Calendar

Aedes Elysiae was dressed in gold.

By dusk, the city had bloomed—lanterns unfurling like petals along the colonnades, flickering above fountains, crowding the carved ribs of temple steps. The scent of crushed thyme and roasting almonds hung thick in the air. A procession of musicians wove through the marble avenues, lyres singing like birds with wine on their tongues. Laughter rose like incense. Laughter, and music, and the sound of many feet dancing where statues once stood solemn.

Phainon let himself be carried by it all.

He wore deep blue tonight—unmarked, unadorned—and allowed himself, for once, to disappear into the crowd. He danced when someone pulled him in, letting his body sway with the rhythm, offbeat and uncaring. He drank wine that tasted of rosehips and cinnamon, smiling when strangers clinked their cups to his. He let his hair get messy. He caught himself laughing—not the hollow kind, but something real, something that sat warm in his chest.

Even joy could still find him.

It was late by the time the festivities thinned. The air grew cooler, the marble streets littered with pomegranate skins and wax drippings, the crowds dissolving into murmured farewells. Torchlight dimmed to embers. The music slowed.

Still a little flushed from wine and movement, Phainon slipped away from the last of the dancers and wandered into the quiet upper quarter. A market stall still flickered with candlelight, its vendor half-asleep behind her baskets. He bought three pomegranates without thinking.

“For good fortune,” the vendor said with a smile. “Or prosperity.”

He said nothing in return, only nodded, and tucked the fruit under his arm.

His home was quiet when he returned. He lit no lamps.

Instead, he found a small knife and set to work in the dim. His sleeves rolled up, he hummed the remnants of a tune he barely remembered—something about a sea god and a drunken poet—as he struggled to slice the pomegranates. The seeds resisted him. His hands were soon slick with red juice, sticky and staining. He swore softly under his breath and laughed, shaking his head.

“Still terrible at this,” he murmured, amused.

He poured the juice of the seeds into a cup and, after a moment’s pause, added a splash of milk. The result turned pink—an unassuming shade, tender and soft, like dawn on marble. He tilted his head at it. Still a strange combination in his opinion, but one he had grown fond of nonetheless.

He poured two cups.

On the balcony, with the breeze tugging gently at the hem of his clothes, he set them both down. One, untouched. The other, he held in his hand as he leaned against the stone, looking out over the rooftops of Aedes Elysiae.

The city glimmered below like a basin of starlight, the sea beyond it whispering against the cliffs.

He didn’t speak at first. Just drank his cup.

Then, quietly, as if offering Phagousa a toast:

“To the crown prince who likes pink.”

The second cup remained full beside him, pale and waiting.

Phainon closed his eyes and breathed. The salt wind curled through his hair. The pomegranate juice lingered on his tongue—sweet, strange, familiar. He did not feel lonely. Not tonight. There were nights when grief clung sharp and tight, but this was not one of them.

Tonight, he remembered.

And that was enough.

(In the name of joy that smelled of pomegranate and light.)

———

Παραλήρημα
delirium.
the body remembering what the mind dares not, and the soul apologizing for it anyway.

———

Year 4929 of the Light Calendar

The fever came with dusk.

Not slowly, like an illness might creep—but all at once, as if Thanatos themselves had turned their gaze upon him and whispered, *burn*. By the time the last light drained from the sky, Phainon could barely sit upright.

His tunic clung to him with sweat, and his skin shivered despite the heat curling like smoke beneath it.

Healers came. They pressed cloths to his brow, left herbs steaming in shallow bowls, said words in calm voices he couldn’t always hear. They told him to rest. To let the fever pass. To let the past go.

He did not listen.

That night, when the moon had risen and the chamber fell into shadows, Phainon stirred. The fever pressed against his bones, but still he rose—slow, stumbling, half-wrapped in the linen that tangled at his legs. His breath hitched. His skin burned.

And there, leaning against the wall where no one had dared to move it, was the old claymore.

It had not left his chambers in years. A relic, they called it. Too heavy for decorum, too stained for parades. But it had been his once. Still was.

His hand found the hilt without thinking.

The cool metal met his palm, and something in his breath softened. He sank to his knees before it, the blade half-dragging, resting flat across his thighs as he bowed his head over it. His sweat fell onto the worn steel. The fever pulsed. His mouth moved.

“I’m sorry,” he whispered.

To what, or whom, he didn’t know.

The blade. The past. Who he had been. The one he had left. The Gods, Titans, or the one he hadn’t prayed to in years. Himself. Someone else. Someone whose name he hadn’t spoken aloud since—

“I’m sorry,” he said again, voice cracking. He gripped the hilt with both hands now, clutching it like a relic of faith, or like it might rise and speak forgiveness back to him.

His forehead pressed to the flat of the blade.

“I didn’t mean to—”

But the words broke there. He did not finish.

The fever dragged him sideways, back against the wall, the weight of the claymore slipping with him. It lay across his lap like a sentinel. His breath slowed. His fingers didn’t let go.

In the moonlight, he looked like a statue left in an abandoned shrine: hollow-eyed, still burning, bound in silence and salt and steel.

By morning, the fever would break.

The healers would find him asleep beside the sword, fingers curled around the hilt, lips parted in sleep. They would not wake him. Only drape a blanket over his shoulders, quietly, and leave the room again.

They would not ask who he had spoken to. Or why, in the thick of the fever, he had wept without sound.

———

Ανείπωτος
Unspoken.
What the hand dares to write, but the lips will not say.

———

There was a box on the upper shelf of his room in Aedes Elysiae—wedged between old ribbons from the solstice races and a bottle of ink that had long since dried. It wasn’t hidden. Just quiet. A place where unfinished things lived.

Inside were letters.

Not many, at first. Then too many to count. Some on expensive parchment, others on scraps torn from the backs of failed drafts. Some dated, some not. A few began with greetings, others with complaints. One just read: *The camps smelled like iron and thyme and I miss it anyway.*

Most of them trailed off. A sentence here. A thought there. All unsent.

He'd written them in odd moods—while waiting for stew to boil, or when the wind outside sounded like footsteps on marble. Sometimes after waking from a dream he couldn't remember, only the feeling of it.

He never said the name. Not even once. But the voice he imagined answering was always the same.

The letters were rarely serious. There was no point in being solemn to a ghost. He teased instead, the way he used to—dry and sharp, but always a little soft beneath the edges. *I heard a bard from Asteris trying to speak Kremnoan today. He said "I would die with honor" and accidentally proposed marriage to a market guard. I nearly choked.* Then, scrawled beneath it: *Your accent would've been better. Or worse. I'd still have listened.*

Other notes were simple:

You would've hated the weather this week—damp and miserable.
Someone brought me almonds sweetened with rosewater. It made me think of your face when you tried candied lemon for the first time. You pretended not to like it. You absolutely liked it.
I miss your voice. I can't remember if it was rough or smooth. I only know it made me stop what I was doing whenever you spoke.

One letter tried to be heartfelt. Two full pages. A story about a dream he'd had, and something about stars over the ocean. He folded it gently. Then tore it up before the ink dried.

Still, the others remained.

The box filled little by little, like a quiet kind of devotion. Not in the sacred way, but in the way a person might water a tree even if it no longer bore fruit. The gesture was what mattered. The reaching. The remembering.

He never expected them to be read.

But in writing, he could almost hear laughter again. Could almost taste the honeyed almonds stolen from his plate. Could almost—almost—believe the silence was not empty, but waiting.

And that was enough, for now.

Year 4931 of the Light Calendar
Month of Balance

The morning broke soft over the village ridges, all honeylight and birdsong. Dew clung to the vine leaves like glass pearls, and the sky was a pale hush of blue—unbroken, unmarred. Phainon stood at the edge of the fields with his hands resting on the haft of a worn wooden hoe, watching the wind pass through barley and spelt.

The elders had risen before him, as they always did, and already the air smelled of turned soil and baking bread. A child darted between the rows of grapevines, arms outstretched like wings, shouting about some heroic beetle he'd found. No one stopped him.

Phainon worked in silence. He was not a farmer, not by trade or upbringing, but there was something about the earth that asked nothing of him. It made no demands of destiny. The soil did not care who he had once been, or what everyone still called him. It simply took what was given—water, light, toil—and, in time, offered something back.

His tunic clung damp to his back, stained at the hem from kneeling. He moved carefully, not because he feared the work, but because he had learned to respect it. He pruned the outer stems of the fig trees, carried buckets of water down the sloped terraces, braced the leaning posts that threatened collapse. When his hands ached, he stretched them open and

rubbed his palms against the rough weave of his belt. When the sun grew high, he paused to share pickled olives with the older workers in the shade.

One of the elders told him a story about her sister chasing a runaway goat across half a valley. He laughed, mouth full, eyes crinkled. They teased him about his softening hands. He lifted them in surrender. “They’ve seen enough blades,” he said, “I think they deserve to pull weeds.”

That afternoon, he helped the miller’s daughter carry sacks of grain from the cart to the storeroom. She offered him a sliver of honeycomb in return. He ate it slow, licking the sweetness from his fingers as he leaned against the wall, watching the dust dance in golden slants of light.

It was a good day. A quiet one. And for the first time in a long while, his shoulders ached not from steel or strain, but from lifting sacks of grain and swinging children onto them, their laughter bright in his ears as they pointed at clouds and demanded to see farther.

The wind stirred the stalks again. Someone called his name from across the field.

And far from that gentle place, beyond the mountains and temples and gilded palaces—

Year 4931 of the Light Calendar, Month of Balance.

Nikador—the Strife Titan, Lance of Fury—fell.

A new god of Strife was born.

———

The earth did not tremble. The sky did not darken.
Peace bloomed like a fig split too ripe—sweet, but fleeting.
And somewhere far from prophecy’s gaze, a god opened his eyes for the first time.
The silence did not break.
It simply shifted.

———

After the new god of Strife rose, the world did not erupt in chaos. Quite the opposite. There were no celestial storms, no wars flaring overnight, no blood-soaked omens scrawled across the earth. Instead, things settled. Quieted.

Borders relaxed. Treaties held. Old grudges felt further away than they had in decades. Soldiers found themselves idle, and the whisper of steel against steel grew rare. For a moment, it seemed as if Strife itself had grown weary of conflict.

People rejoiced—softly, cautiously. Some called it a miracle. Others, a trick. But none could explain it. How could the ascension of a god born of violence lead not to destruction, but to stillness? The lands held their breath. The prophets said little. The world turned slowly under the weight of the unknown.

And yet, beneath the surface, suspicion fermented. Fear makes poor company of peace. Where certainty faded, unease took root.

What did this new god want?

Why had they not spoken?

Why had Kremnos, the land of Strife, grown so silent?

And silence, in time, was taken as defiance.

Exactly one month after the ascension, without warning or formal declaration, attacks were launched against Castrum Kremnos. Borders were breached. Temples razed. The homeland of Strife was branded a threat for refusing to make itself known.

It did not matter that the new god had not raised a hand.

It did not matter that Kremnos had done nothing at all.

To those who feared what they could not control, that was already too much.

They called it *The Night of the Tenth Flame*.

A name pulled from legend. From the spinal mark where Kremnoans trained to strike, to end a fight cleanly. From the sacred fire that burned in the capital's war temples—always in tens, never more, never less. From the old proverb, *Ten flames for restraint, the eleventh for ruin.*

But the eleventh was never lit.

Until now.

No warning was given. No banners flown. No cries of vengeance. No messengers on horse or god. Only silence, once again—this time from those who would answer.

It began just after moonrise.

The first city fell before the bells could ring. The second did not even have time to scream. Ten towns in total were razed that night, and every one burned with the same eerie precision—flames that scorched but did not spread, devastation that seemed too exact for mortals alone.

Witnesses said they saw warriors cloaked in black and bronze, their movements unhurried, their blades clean. Others said it was not soldiers at all, but the land itself rising to avenge the wound. Crops wilted. Livestock fell without cause. Homes turned to ash, not from fire, but from some deeper collapse—foundation, spirit, breath.

No one knew which was true.

No one dared return to find out.

By dawn, the message was clear.

Kremnos had answered. Not in noise. Not in politics. But in the oldest language they knew: annihilation, written with holy flame. No more

questions would be asked. No more provocations tolerated.

And still, the tenth flame burned. Steady. Refusing to cross the line into true ruin. The eleventh remained untouched.

But everyone now understood—it existed.

And should the world forget again, it would be lit.

The breeze that day was soft.

Phainon sat beneath the tree just beyond the garden's edge, one knee bent, the other stretched toward the sun. His eyes were closed. The sky filtered red-gold through the branches, dappling his face and chest in quiet flickers of warmth. Somewhere nearby, cicadas sang a song they'd sung for centuries.

He heard the steps before they stopped behind him.

He didn't open his eyes. He didn't need to. He already knew what they had come to ask, and he already knew what he would do.

The wind shifted, cool and salt-touched. He leaned back against the tree, hands folded over his stomach, the very picture of a man at peace. A man who had spent the last half-decade in near silence, eating olives from local markets, laughing at small festivals, lifting children onto his shoulders in the spring, pressing his thumb to wine lips in the summer. A man who never once heard a word of coronation from Castrum Kremnos.

No formal rites had been performed. No new king named. And by the old customs of the Strife-born—where one must die for the next to reign—there should have been news. There should have been closure.

But there was none. Only silence.

No word of a throne, no whisper of a funeral pyre. No proclamation of the Crown Prince's death. And if there had been, Phainon had not been told.

Which was, in its own way, answer enough.

He had been left behind.

Still, he waited. Quietly. Willingly. Until one day—today—the world remembered he existed again.

The destruction that began at the edge of the continent had finally reached Aedes Elysiae. The temples were anxious, the winds tenser. Too much had happened. Too much had been ignored. A reckoning was long overdue.

And what better offering to send than the Deliverer himself?

He would not run. He never had.

When the hands finally reached him—gentle, but resolute—he did not resist. He stood without a word. Walked without a guide. Gave himself as though it had already been decided. As though it had always been meant to be this way.

Later, they would say he was solemn. Others would say he smiled. Perhaps he did both.

No one could agree on the look in his eyes.

But they would all remember how, when he passed beneath the high gate of the temple, the wind stilled for just a moment. As if even the world had paused to bow its head.

The altar would wait.

The judgment would come.

And he—he would go, as he always had—unflinching.

A flame walking into the pyre.

Not knowing whether he was the sacrifice, or the spark.

Make a choice, they had said.

Two silent attendants approached. Their garb was ceremonial, their faces indistinct in the haze of incense and sunlight. One moved to either side of Phainon. They did not speak. Their touch was light but certain, a nudge of inevitability cloaked in ritual.

Phainon followed.

They led him down a long corridor where the air grew thinner, heavier. The marble underfoot warmed with each step, as though drawing heat from the skin itself. He did not look up, did not allow himself to. There was no need. He knew where this path ended.

He was taken to a final chamber—tall, round, and breathlessly still.

Here, the sky opened above in a perfect circle, and the sunlight did not simply shine; it poured, gold and slow like thickened honey. No wind moved, but the space hummed—quietly, steadily, like something vast exhaling just beyond hearing.

Someone stood in the center.

And Phainon knew immediately: this was no priest. No chosen. No shadow of the divine.

This *was* divinity.

The figure was tall, wrapped in armor the color of forged dusk. Red enamel glinted faintly beneath sun-touched bronze, and on one hand was a gauntlet chased with spiral motifs of flame and chain. The air around him didn’t just shimmer—it bent. Like the world itself was leaning in to listen.

There was no mistaking what he was.

A god.

Phainon didn’t bow. He didn’t speak. He kept his eyes low, stubbornly fixed on the floor as his jaw locked against the pressure blooming behind his ribs.

He would not be the first to move—not for a god who had waited five years to appear.

A pause.

“Name yourself,” came the voice.

It wasn’t loud. It didn’t need to be. It was deep and edged, a voice that felt like it had been shaped in the space between lightning and breath.

Phainon said nothing.

Another step—he could hear it now, the soft brush of boots on stone. The god’s voice again, almost amused.

“No? Then I shall.”

The footsteps stopped just before him.

“Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos.”

It was not a name. It was a declaration.

Phainon didn’t breathe.

And then—warmth.

A gloved hand, impossibly gentle, brushed his jaw. Two fingers beneath his chin. A coaxing touch, patient and strangely careful—as if the god was afraid to break something delicate.

“Won’t you look at me?”

Phainon resisted.

Then he looked.

And his mind stuttered.

It wasn’t immediate recognition. It wasn’t a memory surfacing neatly from the folds of time. It was impact. Sudden and blinding. The kind of knowing that didn’t come from the eyes, but from the bones.

Mydei.

Older. Stranger. Drenched in divinity and war-forged silence. But undeniably, irrevocably *him*.

And Phainon’s knees nearly gave.

Because of course it was him.

Of course he came.

Too late. Too changed.

But still.

Him.

———

Αρχή.
Archē.
The beginning.
Not always loud, but always felt.
A spark, a moment, where everything changes.

———

They walked in silence, down a corridor carved from limestone and mountain breath, each step a measure of some old rhythm neither had spoken aloud in years. The Kremnoans flanking them were a wall of breath and bronze, their expressions blank, focused, utterly still. Discipline clung to them like scent—iron and sweat and the pride of never turning your back to anyone.

And at Phainon’s side walked Mydei.

He didn’t have to look to know. The air shifted around him—thicker, pulled taut like string beneath a bow. There was a heat that radiated outward without burning, the kind of warmth that refused to be named, that curled at the edge of every breath like prophecy left unfinished. Mydei moved with purpose, but without urgency; his presence was neither rushed nor heavy, simply…unignorable, as always. It was not the sort of presence you noticed. It was the kind that made the world notice you noticing it.

Phainon kept his head low, not from shame, but from stubbornness. He would not be the first to speak, nor the first to break. Pride had always sat heavily in his ribs, and if he was to be led to whatever altar waited for him at the end of this hall, then he would go like a mountain, not a lamb.

Still, he saw things.

He saw the way Mydei shifted slightly with each turn, never ahead of him but always beside. He saw the bare line of his shoulder—scarless and sun-darkened, dusted in ash and the faint gold shimmer of power worn too long to be called anything else. The straps of armor crossed only one side of his chest, leaving the other bare, as if the god had never once considered the need for protection there. A crimson cloth hung from his hip, more ceremonial than useful, hem stained from the road. The bronze gauntlet on his right hand—the only piece of armor that seemed meant for use—gleamed with wear, not polish.

There was something quiet in the way Mydei moved. Not arrogance—no, never that—but a sort of practiced containment. One he hadn’t displayed before.

Phainon’s wrists were starting to sting.

The ceremonial cords had tightened during the march, biting into his skin where flesh met bone. Gold beaded there, bright and luminous, catching the light like molten glass. It should have been beautiful. It was only exhausting.

He did not speak, but Mydei stopped anyway.

Without a single word exchanged between them, the god turned toward him. From some unseen fold in the cloth at his waist, he withdrew a strip of linen—not pure white, not embroidered, just simple and worn, the kind of cloth used to bind the wounds of soldiers rather than saints.

Mydei said nothing as he knelt, and the world around them—the guards, the wind, the long passage of stone—seemed to recede with the gesture.

He took Phainon's hand in both of his. The gauntlet came off with a soft click, revealing a hand callused, strong, and far too gentle for what he was supposed to be. He cradled the wrist in his palm, wiping away the blood with the edge of his thumb. The gold clung to his skin like light reluctant to let go.

Phainon watched him, breath caught between something he didn't want to acknowledged.

"You remembered," he said, not meaning to say it at all.

Mydei didn't answer at first. His fingers moved carefully, expertly, winding the linen with slow precision, pressing it into place as if the world depended on it being right.

Then, softly, like something that had waited years to be spoken aloud:

"How could I forget?"

Phainon's throat closed.

And for the first time in five years, he did not feel cold.

They walked for a long while after that, the path winding slow and quiet through pine and stone, the early light falling gold on their backs. Guards trailed behind them at a respectful distance, eyes forward, steps sharp and sure, saying nothing. There was no need.

Phainon kept pace at Mydei's side, not speaking, not looking—not because he didn't want to, but because he was afraid of what would happen if he did. There was too much that still felt unreal. The bandage around his wrist was warm. Mydei's presence beside him was warmer.

At some point, the road curved, and Mydei lifted a hand instinctively, resting it near Phainon's shoulder to guide him past a dip in the earth. The gesture was small, almost thoughtless. But it made something old in Phainon stir.

He blinked. Looked once. Then again.

"…you're still shorter than me," Phainon said, tone mild. Teasing, almost.

Silence dropped like a stone.

Immediately, he regretted it. His mouth parted as if to take it back, to fill the air with something less stupid, less selfish, less him, but then—

Mydei turned to him, expression thunderstruck.

Phainon froze. His heart gave a thump of dismay. Shit.

But then Mydei's mouth opened, and instead of fury or silence or cold godly dismissal, he sputtered, "That's your opening? You waited half a decade to say that?"

He looked genuinely affronted, his brows knitting together in disbelief, and his voice rose a fraction with every word.

"Of all the things you could've said—you mock my height? As if you haven't spent your entire life with the unfair advantage of abnormal genetics and thick-soled boots—"

Phainon's lips curled, laughter warming behind his teeth. There it was. There he was.

The moment was like spring breaking through winter. Familiar. Bright. A little ridiculous. And entirely his.

He stepped in close, fast enough that Mydei faltered, eyes narrowing suspiciously even as he leaned instinctively away.

Phainon caught his hand—not to hold it, not yet—but to lift it slowly, carefully, until the metal of the gauntlet kissed the curve of his lips.

The touch was kind, but the smile he wore was not.

“It’s good to see you again, you know,” he said, voice low. “Though I have to say—I’d imagined this moment a thousand times, and not once did it end with you scowling at me like an angry cat.”

Mydei’s fingers twitched.

His gaze had gone unreadable again, but he didn’t pull away. Didn’t move. And though he tried to keep his expression perfectly still, Phainon could see the faint red creeping up the tips of his ears.

He let the hand go, as if it had always been temporary. As if the kiss had meant nothing.

They kept walking. Mydei didn’t say a word.

But his hand stayed closer after that.

Chapter End Notes

> Rahhhhh how am I gonna finish this on time for the next chapter of Paper Cuts and Pyres😭?
>
> Luckily half the chapter for 3 is kind of written, but it’s rushed so fair warning. I WANT to say I’ll finish today or tomorrow but I don’t know (Unless I make a short chapter which actually yes I just might)
>
> Sorry for the random ending, it was ripped straight from the middle😟
>
> But thank u for reading

Chapter 3: Strife and Solace

Chapter Summary

> Mydei and Phainon have fun in Kremnos! And then when Phainon learns about a certain ritual they have a bit too much fun later down the line.

Chapter Notes

> Sorry abt the late update, I went to school and got blessed with 30 assignments all due tomorrow😍

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Χώρα των Θνητών και των Θεών.
Land of Mortals and Gods.
Where steel sings before the birds do,
and pride is carved into stone
before names are ever given.

———

Castrum Kremnos rose like a scar carved into the earth.

All iron and sun-bleached stone, it was a city that had never learned the word surrender. High walls crowned with bronze pennants caught the wind, and towers stood like watching gods, unmoved and unmoving. The gates loomed ahead—tall, white, and closed—until one of the guards standing beside them shifted his spear upright and looked up.

They saw Mydei, and that was enough.

No words were exchanged. The gates opened, and the soldiers posted there stepped back with the kind of respect that didn’t need bows.

Phainon stepped in slowly, his boots meeting ancient stone.

He said nothing. But something in his shoulders tightened.

It was only once they passed beneath the archway that he paused.

The city inside wasn’t what he expected.

It wasn’t just harsh lines and armor-polished streets. There was grace in the austerity. Temples sculpted into the rock itself, their reliefs telling stories he couldn’t yet understand. Training fields carved into courtyards, ringed with colonnades. Towering statues of long-dead warriors and gods, chiseled into faceless anonymity. Everything was purposeful. Every line in the architecture was sharpened by function, but not without care. Beauty, here, came dressed in discipline.

Phainon, who hadn’t been surprised by a city in years, actually slowed.

His gaze drifted upward, toward the massive stone etchings winding across the nearest wall—interlocking circles and flame motifs woven so intricately they seemed to move.

Mydei noticed. He didn’t say anything at first, only matched Phainon’s pace. They passed under one of the vaulted arches, where the light shifted cool and shadowed. The sounds of the outer world softened, replaced by a quieter rhythm—the muted thud of sparring, the low chant of drill calls, the grind of stone under sandals.

“The wall,” Phainon finally murmured, “it’s… not just decorative?”

“Every circle is a campaign. Every mark is a vow,” Mydei said. “Each line is carved with purpose.”

Phainon looked again. Slower, this time. “They’re…messy.”

“They’re honest.”

He didn’t comment after that, but the expression on his face had changed. His steps carried a tension they hadn’t earlier, but not the usual kind. He wasn’t holding himself back—he was holding something in.

They walked deeper into the city. The path sloped upward in a gentle rise, flanked by buildings that grew sharper in their angles and broader in the shoulders. Homes carved directly into the rock face, their lintels stamped with what looked like familial crests. Every surface bore the weight of its owner's history.

Phainon adjusted his sleeves. His white hair caught in the light, a stark contrast against the dark stone and bronze. A few passersby looked his way—some with mild interest, some with nothing at all. The city did not slow for him. Nor did it hurry.

He stayed close to Mydei without quite meaning to. Just enough that their arms brushed when the street narrowed. Just enough that when the road curved and Phainon's steps faltered, Mydei's hand rested at the small of his back, steadying without comment.

Another pause. This time at a narrow courtyard where young trainees moved through blade forms with absolute focus. Phainon stopped just behind the gate, watching the arcs of motion—measured, clean, efficient.

"That one's good," he said softly, nodding to a boy no older than fifteen.

"He's average," Mydei said.

"Then your average is better than most soldiers I've seen."

"Obviously."

That pulled a faint smile from Phainon, quick and dry. He leaned a little to the side, glancing past Mydei's shoulder at the slope beyond. "Does this city just keep going up?"

"Eventually it ends."

"Helpful."

"You asked a stupid question."

"I missed this," Phainon muttered, almost to himself.

“What?”

“Being insulted like I’m still nineteen.”

“You’ve aged like a plague,” Mydei said without inflection, then turned toward the steps leading further up.

Phainon followed, half-laughing under his breath. “That was uncalled for.”

“It was generous.”

He kept pace, quiet a few steps longer, then let his curiosity start to bleed through.

“What’s that building with the red canopy?”

“Combat ledger hall.”

“And the one with the smoke from the vents?”

“Forge. Not open to guests.”

Phainon’s brows lifted. “Even if I say please?”

Mydei glanced over, expression dry. “Try it and see how many bones you keep.”

Phainon huffed. “You’re always so warm.”

They moved higher, the air thinning a little with the climb. Phainon’s questions came slower now, but only because he was too distracted to ask all of them. His eyes caught everything—the patterns in the stone underfoot, the way statues were half-buried in garden walls, the way water ran through narrow channels along the street edges, cooling the walkways and feeding sparse trees trained into precise shapes.

And then, without warning, he veered.

“Wait—”

“Phainon.”

“Just a second, I swear—”

He was already down the next walkway, quick on his feet. Mydei followed without urgency, but with purpose. When he caught up, Phainon had paused in front of a tall obelisk at the corner of a terrace. The base was wrapped in low carvings, spiraling upward.

“What is it?” Phainon asked.

“A remembrance marker. Names of those who died during the siege of Tareth.”

Phainon ran a hand just above the stone, not quite touching it. “They’re so small. The letters.”

“There were too many.”

Something about the way he said it made Phainon glance at him. Mydei didn’t elaborate.

They stood there a moment longer before Mydei’s hand came to rest against Phainon’s side again—light but firm. A wordless nudge.

“You’re wandering,” he said.

“Since when is that illegal?”

“Since I have to keep you from stepping into sacred grounds by accident.”

Phainon turned, expression too wide-eyed to be innocent. “Have I?”

“Twice.”

He blinked. “Well. That’s not technically illegal.”

“Do you want to be carried?”

“That’s not the threat you think it is.”

But he didn’t pull away when Mydei steered him back toward the main road, fingers still settled at his waist as if anchoring him to the moment. People still stared now and then—especially when Phainon got excited about something. A few scowled. Some watched curiously. One elderly man actually raised a brow at Mydei and shook his head, muttering under his breath.

Mydei pretended not to notice. Phainon absolutely noticed.

“Was that a disapproving elder glare just now?”

“Focus.”

“I am. On cultural exchange.”

“You’re embarrassing.”

“Then you shouldn’t have let me in.”

“I didn’t.”

Another laugh, warmer this time.

Eventually, Mydei sighed and raised a hand in a slow, familiar motion. The guards following at a distance straightened—then peeled off without a word. Dismissed.

Phainon glanced over, surprised. “You sure?”

“No.”

But he didn’t take it back.

They rounded a quiet bend in the stone walkway, where the crowd thinned and the city opened into a quieter courtyard—less spectacle, more memory. No grand statues or gilded gates. Just an arched column that had stood for

centuries, worn smooth by the weather, etched with the old tongue in deep, deliberate lines.

Phainon slowed again. His gaze lifted, steady.

The inscription wasn't immediately easy to read—the script ancient, more angled than the modern variant—but he took his time. His mouth moved soundlessly at first, wrapping his tongue around the words as he translated:

"Strength is not in the blade," he recited carefully, "but in the hand that chooses when not to draw it."

Well, "That's… a better lesson than most nations ever teach their soldiers."

Behind him, Mydei stilled.

He hadn't stopped when Phainon first wandered off, but now he did. Head tilted just slightly, voice attentive:

"You know Kremnoan?"

Phainon didn't answer right away. His hand brushed the edge of the pillar, careful, like the stone might flinch.

"I've learned," he said finally, still not looking at him.

A silence lingered, but not the uncomfortable kind. It settled between them like a held breath.

Then Mydei's voice came again, softer than before. Not quiet with caution, but with something gentler. Something almost fond.

"Is that so?"

Phainon turned toward him. There wasn't hesitation in the way he met his eyes—just something a little bare.

"I didn't want to sound like a foreigner," he said. "Not the next time we spoke."

That paused Mydei more fully than anything else had all day. For a moment, he said nothing.

Then he stepped forward. Not close enough to startle, but enough that his presence felt warmer again.

“You never did,” he said.

Simple with no flourish. But it landed just as heavy, soft and certain.

Phainon’s mouth quirked—not a smirk, not a grin. Something akin to a real smile, pulled from some long-unused place.

He didn’t say anything in reply. Just reached out, a slow curl of fingers around Mydei’s, firm but unhurried.

Their hands found each other with little fanfare.

Like they were used to it.

They stood like that for a few seconds, until Phainon glanced toward a narrow alleyway just beyond the road.

A warm scent drifted through it—cinnamon, honey, something powdered and faintly toasted.

His eyes flicked toward the storefront at the end of the lane, painted shutters thrown open to reveal a display of sweets.

“Do you still have a sweet tooth?” he asked without turning, still holding Mydei’s hand. “Or am I about to drag a grown man into a bakery against his will?”

Mydei huffed, half a breath of disbelief.

“You’re already dragging him.”

Phainon laughed under his breath. “Good.”

They started walking again, fingers still threaded.

Hands interlocked, like they've always been.

They didn't keep to the main roads.

Phainon insisted on taking every offshoot path and side street he found, half out of curiosity and half because Mydei kept letting him. They slipped past fields where soldiers practiced drills in tight formation, past bathhouses that steamed softly in the morning light, and through a tucked-away garden where everything smelled of rosemary and iron.

At one point, Phainon dared Mydei to scale the outer wall of the training coliseum just to "get a better view." Mydei didn't even argue—he just handed over his gauntlet first, muttering something about how *if he fell, he was taking Phainon with him.*

They made it to the top. Phainon declared it "underwhelming." Mydei nearly shoved him off.

Later, they ducked into a courtyard where young acolytes were sparring with short spears. Phainon watched for a while, then declared he could win against at least one of them with a stick and one hand tied. Mydei laughed—an actual laugh, low and brief—and said, "That's generous. You'd last five seconds." Phainon took that as a challenge. It ended with him flat on his back after tripping and a teenager politely helping him up while trying not to grin. Mydei clapped once. "Four seconds," he said.

Phainon threw a rock at him. Missed.

They shared spiced fruit from a market vendor after a game of who could guess the most names of ancient warriors carved into the plaza's walls. Mydei won by three. Phainon accused him of cheating. Mydei didn't even deny it—just popped another slice into his mouth and said, "Should've studied more, then."

For a while, they forgot the weight of titles and time. There was no offerings, no sacrifice, and no gods or titans. Just voices overlapping and half-smiles traded without thinking.

Just them.

And the city, which had once loomed around Phainon like something sharp and unwelcome, now felt less like a wound and more like a memory—one he hadn’t lived through, but could maybe still belong to.

By the time the sun began slipping behind the jagged rooftops, the sky had turned the color of pressed embers. Golden haze pooled along the alleys, warm and slow, casting long silhouettes behind every step they took. The city, once bristling with motion and metal, had softened into something slower.

Phainon stretched, spine arcing, arms raised overhead as he exhaled through his teeth. His tunic had come half-loose at the collar; he made no effort to fix it. The back of his hand brushed a stone wall still radiating the day’s heat.

Ahead of him, Mydei walked in silence, clearly smug.

Another parcel of pastries tucked beneath his arm. Another dumb contest, won with a well-timed answer and a particularly cruel glint in his eye.

Phainon hadn’t said anything when he lost.

He’d thrown the match somewhere in the middle on purpose—just to see the way Mydei lit up when he won. The faintest glimmer of pride at the edges of his otherwise straight face. That subtle softening when he reached for a candy like it was a trophy.

Phainon could’ve beaten him. But then he wouldn’t have seen that expression. The one he remembered from years ago—less practiced than a smile, but just as warm.

They were still talking—bantering, teasing, arguing about which ancient tactician had once claimed the baths at the southern terrace. Mydei claimed he didn’t care. Phainon claimed he was lying.

Then something shifted.

A blur darted through the crowd.

Mydei didn’t flinch when the child hit him—not hard, just enough to stagger back with a surprised, winded noise. She couldn’t have been older than seven. Dirt on her knees, hair loose, wide eyes already bracing for the worst.

Phainon’s hand twitched, instinctual.

But Mydei had already moved. He crouched in one smooth motion—not at all irritated as one would expect. Quiet hands dusted off the girl’s tunic with minimal fuss, gaze sweeping over her for signs of injury. He wasn’t rough or performative, simply concerned even if it didn’t seem like it.

The child blinked up at him, nodded once like she understood something, then turned and sprinted back down the lane without another word.

Phainon hadn’t moved.

He was still watching Mydei, something unreadable behind his eyes. Admiration, maybe. Or fondness, helplessly and utterly fond.

“You’re staring,” Mydei said as he rose, brushing his palms off against his thighs.

Phainon didn’t look away. “So?”

“So say something or stop doing it.”

“I’m debating.”

“Debating what?”

“If saying it will make you insufferable.”

Mydei snorted. “Too late.”

They kept walking.

The light had shifted by now, deeper oranges sliding into a soft slate blue. Somewhere nearby, a stringed instrument was being tuned, the notes climbing idly through the air like drifting smoke.

Phainon let the silence hang for a moment. Then, lightly:

“You’re gentle.”

Mydei scoffed immediately. “There’s no word for gentle in in the Kremnoan language.”

Phainon’s brow arched. “Isn’t there?”

“Strange,” he murmured, “I thought it went something like… ‘The way the hand steadies the blade before it falters.’”

Mydei didn’t answer.

He didn’t look over, didn’t stop walking. But something shifted. A small catch in his step, almost imperceptible. The type of stillness that happens when someone hears something they weren’t expecting.

Phainon didn’t press him. Just kept walking at his side.

The moment passed without comment, but the space between them had changed—eased somehow, as if whatever tension Mydei carried had loosened by a thread.

Phainon glanced over, catching the faintest curl of Mydei’s fingers around the pastry wrap. Nothing dramatic. Just a subtle tell.

He didn’t smile, but he felt something close.

His Kremnoan was far from perfect.

But apparently, it didn’t need to be.

It was enough.

Enough to be heard. Enough to stay close.

And maybe, just maybe—enough to soften something in the man beside him.

The gates of the inner palace opened when they arrived, the sound of stone grinding against stone echoing through the colonnade. The guards posted on either side didn’t glance his way. Bronze-faced and silent, they held their formation as if carved from the walls themselves. Above them, the sun caught the edge of the architrave and set the laureled reliefs aglow.

Mydei stopped at the threshold.

His hand, still carrying the last of the pastries, adjusted his grip as he turned toward Phainon. “This is where we part,” he said.

Phainon didn’t answer at first. He glanced past him to the hall that yawned ahead, the edges of his earlier joy starting to retreat like tidewater.

Mydei held his gaze a moment longer. Then, quieter: “You’ll be shown where to go.”

There was nothing else to say. Not here. Not with footsteps already echoing ahead, and attendants approaching from the opposite side like a quiet storm.

Still, something in Mydei lingered—for a breath, maybe two. A shift in his weight, the briefest glance toward Phainon’s hand. Then, with practiced ease, he stepped back into the rhythm expected of him, the ornament wrapped around his waist settling at his heels as he turned and disappeared down the western corridor.

Phainon exhaled, more of a release than a sigh.

And then they came.

The attendants approached like a tide. Four of them, maybe five—draped in charcoal-grey cloth, wrists bound in white cord, each moving with unbroken purpose. They took his cloak first—The one Mydei handed to him at some point—folding it once before it disappeared into a cedar-lined coffer. Another offered him a bronze-hilted knife, the edge dull but exposed. He accepted it and held it as he had seen others do—blade outward, wrist relaxed.

A basin was placed at his feet, wide and shallow. The water inside smelled of salt and bay. An older woman motioned for him to kneel, and when he did not move quickly enough, she dipped a cloth into the basin and began at his face. The corners of his eyes. The line of his jaw. His hands.

Another brushed his arms with oil—green-gold and dense, smelling of char and thyme. She said nothing, only worked the salve into his skin with both palms, moving from shoulder to wrist in practiced strokes.

“Live salve,” someone said as they passed. “To keep the limbs alert.”

A vessel of wine was set in his hand. Strong, bitter, touched with resin. He drank it all, knowing it was expected.

The food followed next. A plate of figs, cuts of cured boar, a folded disc of blackbread, still warm. No one gestured for him to eat, but the tray remained within reach until he did. Across the room, a pair of acolytes lit a brazier and burned ironroot and rosemary, the scent sharp enough to draw tears.

He felt his sandals loosened. Ashwater was traced over his wrists. A boy no older than sixteen touched a blade flat to his shoulder and stepped back without a word. The meaning was clear enough.

Nothing here was done for comfort. Everything served a function—cleansing, restoring, marking, preparing.

When the ceremonial shawl was brought forth, Phainon stood without needing to be told. It was heavier than it looked. Dyed red, lined in silver thread, the scent of cedar still clinging to the wool. It fell over his frame like a mantle of silence.

He said nothing through any of it. His thoughts were quiet and focused.

And as the last of the attendants stepped away, their work finished, he looked down the hall ahead.

The joy of the day—the laughter, the idle games, the feel of Mydei's hand—had faded, not in a cruel way, but in the way morning fades into dusk.

This was the palace. This was what waited.

And Phainon let himself remember, at last, why he had come.

The room they brought him to was quiet. Thick stone walls, low light. A basin in the corner, a single window high above the floor, and a bed laid with dark wool.

Phainon didn't look around for long.

The door closed behind him with a solid sound, and he stood there for a moment, eyes adjusting to the dim. The cloak still hung off his shoulders. He pulled it off and dropped it over the nearest bench. His boots followed.

He barely made it to the bed.

No thought spared to the sword still sheathed at his side. No second glance at the space. He lay back, head hitting the bolster, and the tension in his spine bled out all at once. Muscles slackened. Eyes shut.

He was asleep before the next breath left him.

Not the restless kind. Not haunted or guarded. It was the type that takes you all at once, like being claimed by the dark behind your eyelids. A body finally given permission to stop.

———

Μνήμη
Memory
A thing older than sight.
Not a recollection, but a return

———

Phainon dreamed.

In the dream, the sky was iron, the kind that bruises before dawn. A cliff rose before him, jagged and bare, its face scorched as if by something once divine. The wind moved across it slowly, steady as breath drawn through the teeth.

High above, a figure hung from the rock. Not bound with iron or rope, but held by the will of the earth itself, limbs fixed in place, ribs rising with slow defiance. His face was turned away, but the shape of him was familiar—way too familiar. A body that bore the silence of endurance. A stillness that spoke of centuries.

Far below, someone walked the valley floor. His feet were dark with ash. Smoke curled at his shoulders, trailing from the hollow of his palms. He moved without hurry, though every step left embers in his wake. He held no torch, no vessel—only fire cupped in his hands as though it had always belonged there.

Phainon watched both: the one who burned, and the one who watched him burn.

He could not say which one he was meant to be.

He only knew the air tasted of salt and old stone, and that when the wind shifted, he heard voices in a tongue he knew but had never spoken—words passed down through smoke and myth, carried by those who had chosen to take what gods once kept.

And when he opened his eyes, the scent of rosemary still lingered on the edge of his breath.

The light had shifted—no longer the burnished gold of late afternoon, but something cooler, grayer, filtered through high latticework and the slow flutter of hanging veils. For a moment, he didn't remember where he was. The dream still clung to his skin.

Then movement caught his eye.

He sat up fast—too fast—and nearly collided with the figure standing at the edge of the room. Another stood behind them. And another, half-shrouded in the light.

Phainon blinked.

They weren't intruders. They weren't armed. They weren't even surprised.

It was the attendants again. The same ones from before—or mostly the same. One of them adjusted the folds of a ceremonial cloth over his arm. Another poured water into a copper basin with a calm, practiced rhythm.

Phainon exhaled, scrubbing a hand down his face. "I thought I was alone."

No one answered.

He tried again. "Good morning?" Maybe. He wasn't entirely sure what hour it was. "Evening?"

Still nothing.

Then, mercifully, one of the newer attendants—slighter in frame, with an accent that wasn't Kremnoan—stepped forward and gave a small, polite nod. "You rested longer than expected. It's nearly dusk."

Phainon pushed the blanket aside and swung his legs over the edge of the bed. "You all don't talk much, do you?"

The attendant offered a hint of a smile. "We speak when needed."

Phainon raised a brow. “Is it needed now?”

There was a pause. Then: “Yes.”

That caught his attention. He straightened, rubbing sleep from his eyes. “Is something happening?”

The attendant hesitated just long enough for it to be noticeable. “We’ve come to prepare you.”

“For what?”

A longer pause this time. The faintest crease of sympathy crossed the attendant’s expression.

“I suggest you sit,” he said gently. “This might take a while.”

Time passed.

It must have—though Phainon wasn’t entirely sure how much.

He sat motionless as the attendants worked around him, their hands steady, their movements smooth, practiced, unconcerned. Someone adjusted the folds of a thin linen robe around his shoulders—white, almost translucent in the light, and held together by little more than a twisted cord at the waist. Another knelt to fasten soft sandals to his feet, looped with pale leather thongs.

Phainon didn’t stop them this time.

Not because he’d finally accepted this ritual with poise and grace—but because he was in complete, absolute shock. The kind that turned noise into static and thoughts into an echo chamber. His eyes were wide, unfocused. His mouth had been half-open for what might’ve been ten minutes.

No one seemed concerned.

The older woman from before adjusted the hem of the robe. Another tucked a carved token of protection beneath the belt. A third gently dusted his hair with powdered laurel ash.

Phainon sat there. Silent. Blank.

Still processing.

When he finally spoke, it was faint, hoarse. “You’re joking.”

One of the younger attendants—yes, the one who had the decency to actually *talk* to him—glanced up with a serene expression and the air of someone accustomed to confused nobles. “I assure you, I am not.”

Phainon blinked, slow and mechanical. “You’re telling me,” he said carefully, “that this rite—this sacred, ancient rite—involves… being *witnessed* during…”

A pause.

Another blink.

He couldn’t even finish the sentence.

The attendant offered a calm, if apologetic, smile. “It is considered a symbolic offering of unity. Flesh honors flesh. Spirit is sealed through exposure. The old texts describe it as—”

Phainon raised a hand. “No. No, no, no. I don’t want to know what the old texts describe it as.”

The other attendants continued dressing him, undisturbed. One of them tied a ribbon around his upper arm like this was completely normal.

Which apparently, it was.

He let out a slow, measured breath and looked up at the ceiling like maybe if he stared hard enough, the gods would smite him out of mercy.

“They’re going to *watch*?” he asked, his voice rising in disbelief.

“They are not meant to speak,” the attendant clarified, as if that was the problem.

Phainon stared at him. “Oh, well. That makes it *better*.”

He shot to his feet so fast the linen swished around his knees. “I swear to *every* divine name I can remember, when I see that man—*your king*—I’m going to strangle him with his own sash.”

The attendant held up both palms in a soothing gesture. “He anticipated you might feel this way.”

“Oh, *did* he?”

“As such,” the attendant continued with that infuriating composure, “he’s made… adjustments.”

Phainon narrowed his eyes. “Adjustments?”

The attendant nodded. “You are not required to be seen. There will be no gathered assembly.”

Phainon paused. That did help. A little.

He narrowed his eyes further. “And?”

“And,” the attendant went on, “the rite will still be performed in a space of authority, in accordance with tradition—but modified to account for your status and privacy.”

“‘Status and privacy.’” Phainon repeated slowly. “Does that mean I still have to—?”

“Yes.”

“I’m going to kill him.”

The smile didn’t waver. “We’re to bring you to him soon.”

Phainon looked down at the white fabric. At the silver thread stitched into the edge. At the dried herbs tucked into the cord at his waist.

All that thoughtful detail. All that pageantry. All that nerve.

“Gods help him,” he muttered. “Because I’m going to do it slow.”

The attendant bowed slightly. “He said you might say that too.”

Phainon turned toward the door. And kept muttering.

Something about fire, and payback, and *public execution via lacework.*

They moved him through it all with steady hands and calm expressions, as though he weren’t moments away from a rite that apparently involved ceremonial nudity and trauma bonding.

First came the *katharmos*—the purification.

His skin was washed once more after he absentmindedly tripped and collected dirt on the way down, this time with chilled springwater steeped in crushed fig leaves and ashroot. He was led to a second basin—larger, deeper—and bade to step in. A young acolyte poured water from a red-etched pitcher over his shoulders while murmuring something too complicated for Phainon to catch.

When he stepped out, another draped him in fresh cloth—thinner than before, the weave so fine it caught on his skin like wind. A belt was tied, loose but secure, and a length of white wool was slung over his shoulder, the mark of one who would give and be given to.

They placed the corolla upon him last—a band of hammered gold leaves, olive-shaped and unnaturally bright beneath the dimming torchlight. It pressed against his brow with quiet finality, the weight of it not heavy, but unmistakable. The acolyte who set it there did not meet his eyes, only stepped back and bowed her head once, low and long.

Then came the sandals—soft-soled and laced with rawhide, wrapped in a spiral up his calves like a slow-ascending chain. A final line of ochre was drawn across his sternum with two fingers, then pressed into the skin with the heel of the acolyte's palm. The oil was scented with smoked pine and thyme. Bitter. Ancient.

He was clean, robed, crowned, and marked.

Prepared.

They opened a door without telling him to follow. A narrow passage yawned ahead, low-ceilinged and carved from green-veined limestone. No windows. Only wall sconces lit with flame and the hush of sandal-steps on marble. The torchbearer moved without speaking, her pace steady and unhurried—as if she were escorting someone not to an audience, but to an altar.

Phainon walked after her.

The wool draped over his shoulder brushed the inside of his arm. His hands were bare. His mouth was dry. Every step forward stirred the silence like silt.

At the far end of the passage stood a pair of doors, nearly twice his height and shaped with a deep-arched lintel carved in the likeness of coiled serpents and spears. Laurel boughs had been hung above them, still green, though their scent had long since faded.

No one else stood guard. No horns were blown.

The torchbearer turned to him at last.

"You will enter alone," she said. Her voice was even. Not harsh, but not soft either. "He waits."

Phainon frowned, then stepped forward instinctively—before his breath caught and he looked up again, as if seeing the doors anew. For a moment, his legs did not move.

The woman didn’t prod him, didn’t touch his arm or nudge him along. She simply stepped aside, lowering her torch.

Phainon stepped past her, the sound of his feet echoing off the stone floor as the doors eased open ahead of him.

The hall inside was colder than the corridors before. The air carried a hush, the kind that belonged to places older than memory. No torchlight—only the narrow shaft of sun from above, and the figure seated beneath it.

Mydei sat without the usual trappings—no guards, no courtiers, no performance. Just a high-backed seat of red crystals.

His posture was composed, but not rigid. One leg rested over the other, his fingers loosely curled over the armrest. He looked like he’d been waiting a while—but not impatiently. Like he’d expected Phainon to hesitate.

“You’re late,” Mydei said, in that familiar deadpan that made it difficult to tell if he meant it seriously or not.

Phainon paused halfway down the steps. “You’re underdressed for a man who’s about to be revered.”

“Clothes were never the holy part,” Mydei replied. “You should know. You’re wearing tissue.”

Phainon glanced down at the thin folds of ceremonial white clinging to him and gave an exaggerated sigh. “Is this even legal?”

“Depends on the city-state.”

Phainon resumed walking. His steps were careful, but not nervous—not slow, just measured. “You could’ve mentioned the full ritual earlier.”

“And you would’ve come?”

“I would’ve sprinted into the sea.”

Mydei hummed. “I thought as much.”

Phainon came to a stop several paces away. The space between them felt too open for the way Mydei was looking at him—too quiet for what had been asked. And maybe that’s why the teasing faltered, if only slightly.

“Is it really necessary?” he asked, just tired.

Mydei’s gaze didn’t waver. “No.”

Phainon blinked. “No?”

“You can leave,” Mydei said simply. “I’ll deal with the elders. They’ll protest. Then I’ll remind them I’m still their god.”

He said it plainly, without vanity.

Phainon didn’t answer right away. His fingers twitched slightly at his sides, like they were trying to decide whether to curl into fists or tuck themselves away.

“You’d do that?” he asked, quieter now.

“I didn’t bring you here to trap you.”

There was a long pause.

Then Phainon gave a small, unconvincing shrug. “Well,” he said lightly, “I already bathed three times. I’d hate for that to go to waste.”

Mydei smiled—one of the rare, tired ones that didn’t reach his eyes right away. But when it did, it was warm.

Phainon looked away before it could settle too deep. “You’re lucky I’m sentimental,” he muttered.

“I thought you were just stupid.”

“That too.”

For a moment, neither of them moved. The silence wasn’t heavy—simply suspended, like the held breath before a bowstring is released.

Then Mydei unfolded from the throne and stepped forward.

He didn’t reach for Phainon.

Not yet.

But he stopped close enough that Phainon could see the detail of the lion-clasp, and the faint shimmer of something painted at the edge of his jaw—a trace of ash, or kohl, or some ceremonial pigment not yet washed away.

“I’m serious,” he said again, softer now. “The rites can be… adjusted. The old men will complain, but I’m not particularly interested in what they think.”

Phainon’s gaze flicked to the floor, then back up. “That right?”

Mydei gave a faint huff—almost a laugh. “I am again, regrettably, still their god. They’ll manage.”

Phainon’s lips twitched, and for a moment it looked like he might crack a joke to deflect it all. But instead, he reached out, touching the edge of Mydei’s shoulder wrap. Just fabric.

“And what if I said no?” he asked. “Would you pout about it?”

“I might.” Mydei tilted his head, eyes narrowing slightly in amusement. “But I’d keep my hands to myself and complain about it later in writing.”

Phainon blinked. “You keep journals?”

“Not anymore,” Mydei said. “The last one caught fire.”

“That on purpose?”

“Not… entirely.”

The banter was enough to ease the tightness in Phainon’s shoulders, but it hadn’t dulled the heat between them. He took a step forward. Then another. Until he was close enough that their breath mingled.

He kissed him.

Slowly, unfaltering—like he was taking a temperature. Mydei didn’t rush him, didn’t press in. But when Phainon didn’t pull away, Mydei lifted a hand and cradled the side of his jaw with the kind of care that made Phainon want to mock him just to break it.

Instead, he murmured against his mouth, “You’re not half as composed as you pretend to be.”

Mydei arched a brow. “Neither are you.”

“Fair,” Phainon admitted. Then—before he could think too hard—he pushed lightly against Mydei’s chest, urging him back into the throne.

The impact wasn’t harsh. Mydei allowed it, sitting with a sort of bemused dignity, his hands still resting on the arms of the seat like he wasn’t entirely sure if he was supposed to be ruling or being ruled.

Phainon stepped into the space between his knees. Then, without ceremony, he climbed into his lap and settled there—solid, bracing, unwilling to give himself time to second guess.

Mydei’s hands hovered for a moment, unsure of where to land. “Are you sure?” he asked, quieter now. “You don’t have to prove anything. Not to me.”

Phainon looked at him. Really looked.

Then he said, a little dryly, “Let’s just hope you’re better at this than you are at answering riddles.”

And Mydei, finally smiling in a way that wasn’t hidden or subtle or dignified, leaned up to kiss him again. “That depends,” he said against his lips. “Is there a prize for winning this one?”

Phainon didn’t answer.

But the way his fingers slid up under the edge of Mydei’s wrap said enough.

Phainon glanced over his shoulder at the discarded robe, then picked it up and slung it around his shoulders—not tied, not even fully closed, but enough to feel like he hadn’t given up all self-respect just yet.

“This can’t be that hard,” he muttered under his breath, which was precisely the kind of thing a man says moments before a tactical disaster.

Mydei hadn’t moved from the throne. He watched in silence, elbow resting on the armrest, thumb against his mouth as though weighing some unspoken calculus.

Phainon stepped in close again, gaze level. He hesitated only a second before bracing a hand on the arm of the throne—and then the other on Mydei’s shoulder. He didn’t ease into the kiss. He didn’t need to.

It was like last time, firm, steady, meant to test something—not if Mydei wanted it, but if he could keep up.

Mydei answered without pause, one hand rising to catch the edge of the robe as it slid from Phainon’s shoulder. Their mouths parted just long enough for Mydei to say, voice low but amused, “You sound very confident for someone who’s—”

Phainon cut him off with another kiss, rougher this time.

“Then prove me wrong,” he said against his lips.

The rest—whatever came next—was no longer a matter of necessity.

It was choice. Willing, undeniable.

And the gods could do what they wanted with that.

The elders entered as though nothing was happening.

As though Phainon wasn’t still straddling Mydei in the throne, legs trembling, mouth bruised and wet where he’d bitten down too hard. As though Mydei’s hands weren’t still gripping his waist, keeping him in place even now, even after the sharp sound Phainon had made when he’d finally sunk down all the way, his own nails leaving red streaks across Mydei’s chest.

The cloak was Mydei’s. Crimson, heavy, warm where it had been draped over Phainon’s shoulders, concealing what little dignity he had left. His own thin robes had been stripped from him like they were nothing, tossed aside without a thought. And maybe he should have protested, should have pulled the fabric tighter around himself, but there was no undoing this, not with Mydei still inside him, not with the heat of it still coiling in his gut.

Not with the council stepping past them like this was any other meeting.

Phainon barely breathed.

He could hear them talking—measured, indifferent, already discussing war and treaties and border disputes as if they weren’t there. As if this wasn’t happening.

His thighs ached where they pressed against the carved shape of the throne, knees spread wide, hips locked into the curve of Mydei’s lap. He wanted to move, to lift himself off, to regain some control, but Mydei just exhaled a quiet laugh, fingers flexing against his waist. Holding him there. Keeping him full.

Bastard.

“Disruptions along the river,” someone said, voice smooth, disinterested.

“Expected,” another replied.

A shift beneath him—Mydei adjusting his grip, subtle but unmistakable, a reminder of exactly how deep he was, exactly what Phainon had let happen here. He swallowed down the noise that threatened to escape, shoved his

face against Mydei’s shoulder instead, sinking his teeth in to keep himself quiet.

The taste of metal and skin filled his mouth, but Mydei didn’t flinch.

If anything, he sounded amused when he whispered, “Careful. They might think you like it.”

Phainon would kill him. Right after this, right after he could think again, he was going to kill him.

“He yielded?”

It wasn’t even a real question. Just a formality. Something to be recorded in whatever archive they kept of this, another name added to a list of those who had submitted to the Strife God’s claim.

Phainon tensed. Mydei, the bastard, just had a subtle smile against his temple.

“He did.”

The elders nodded, already moving on.

Phainon couldn’t.

The discussion pressed forward, steady and impersonal, a tide of negotiations and military reports washing past him.

“Our eastern borders remain unstable. Raids, mostly. Small incursions.”

“They’ll wait to see what we do here. If we don’t answer soon, they’ll take it as permission.”

Phainon barely heard them. The weight of Mydei’s cloak was stifling, the air thick with sweat and incense. Every shift of his body sent heat curling up his spine, his thighs trembling where they still straddled Mydei’s lap. And still, Mydei hadn’t let him move—not fully.

He could feel it when Mydei's attention wavered, when his grip loosened just slightly in favor of tapping lazy fingers against the arm of the throne. Not absent, but not focused.

Phainon scowled, fingers curling into the fabric at Mydei's shoulder.

Well, if Mydei wanted to be unbothered, he could fix that.

He shifted, just enough to press down where he knew Mydei would feel it, rolling his hips in a slow, deliberate motion. He didn't miss the way Mydei's breath hitched, the brief pause in the conversation before the council carried on as though nothing had happened.

"My prince," one of the elders murmured, not even looking up from the parchment he was marking. "The offering seems restless."

There was a beat of silence. Then Mydei responded unconcerned.

"My consort," he corrected. His hand traced the line of Phainon's spine, pressing between his shoulder blades to keep him close. "And he has waited five years. Let him tremble."

Heat pricked the back of Phainon's neck, but he refused to let it show. Instead, he huffed, his next movement just a little sharper, more insistent.

If Mydei wanted to play this game, then fine. But Phainon had never played to lose.

Phainon moved with slow, measured rolls of his hips, careful, restrained—at least as much as he could be. His thighs burned with it, his pulse an unsteady thing in his throat, but he refused to let anything slip past his lips.

He still had some dignity left.

The council continued their discussion without pause, voices blending together, speaking of war, of numbers, of land to be claimed or defended. Mydei's fingers skimmed idly along his back, tracing the curve of his spine beneath the red cloak, then pressing against the dip of his waist, heat

pooling where he touched. He wasn’t even fully paying attention to Phainon.

“Barbaric.”

“Then reclaim your civility,” Mydei murmured, barely moving his lips, his voice smooth. His thumb dragged down the jut of Phainon’s hip. “I won’t stop you.”

Phainon exhaled sharply, annoyed, grinding down hard enough to make Mydei’s breath catch. A small victory.

“I hate you,” he whispered, even as he did it again.

“Lie better.” Mydei’s fingers tightened, his grip nearly bruising now, and Phainon felt the tremor Mydei tried to suppress.

Mydei’s hands adjusted Phainon’s waist, but it didn’t deter him. If anything, he felt the flicker of amusement in the way Phainon adjusted, dragging the moment out longer, making it worse.

“Losses?” Mydei asked, voice even, steady. Barely.

A councilor began to answer, and Mydei tried to focus, tried to—

Phainon shifted just slightly, rocking down in a way that sent heat curling through Mydei’s spine.

His breath hitched before he could stop it. Just a fraction of a second, just enough of a pause for the silence to stretch too long.

A glance from one of the elders. Just that. Not suspicion, not anything more, but still enough to make Mydei’s teeth clench.

Phainon had heard it. He could feel it in the way his body went lax with satisfaction, the ghost of a smile pressing against Mydei’s jaw as he leaned in, taunting him in silence.

Enough.

Mydei exhaled slowly, fingers flexing against Phainon’s hips, before he moved.

A shift, sharp and sudden, a thrust up that made Phainon jolt, a sharp breath sucked between his teeth.

He stiffened, hands clutching at Mydei’s shoulders, nails pressing into his skin. A noise almost escaped him—Mydei could feel the way it caught in his throat, swallowed down at the last second.

And now Mydei was the one looking at him.

“Something wrong?” he murmured, just for him.

Phainon’s grip tightened, his body tense where it had once been languid.

“Bastard,” he whispered back, breathless.

Mydei only hummed, his attention smoothly returning to the conversation. “Continue.”

The council obeyed.

Phainon, however, was very, very still.

The meeting stretched on, unbroken, the discussion shifting from war to governance, from land disputes to trade routes, from famine preparations to city defenses. The elders spoke with the same measured cadence, the same quiet certainty, their words filling the vast chamber in even, deliberate waves.

Phainon, by contrast, was barely breathing.

He had stopped moving entirely, his restraint absolute, body tense as Mydei’s hands remained on his hips. Mydei hadn’t done it again—not yet—but Phainon could feel the threat of it. The pressure of fingers just tight enough to remind him that he wasn’t in control.

And worse, Mydei was—infuriatingly—perfectly composed again. His voice steady, his answers crisp. He listened without strain, replied without hesitation, all while keeping Phainon exactly where he wanted him.

Phainon swallowed, his head dipping slightly against Mydei's shoulder, eyes hooded as he listened—not to the council, not to the matters of war and state, but to the measured pace of Mydei's breathing. The steady rise and fall of his chest, the slow expansion of his ribs against Phainon's own.

He was ignoring him.

He was actively ignoring him.

And Phainon should have been grateful for it, should have been relieved that Mydei had refocused, had turned his attention back to his court, had spared Phainon the humiliation of another slip.

But he wasn't.

He was annoyed.

His fingers curled against Mydei's shoulders, his grip testing, nails dragging faintly across skin, his body shifting just enough to press closer, forcing Mydei to feel him again.

Still, Mydei didn't react.

Phainon exhaled sharply, irritated, and let his lips brush the column of Mydei's throat, just a whisper of warmth against his skin.

That got him something. A fractional pause. A twitch of fingers against his waist.

But still, Mydei did not break.

He only continued.

"The borderlands?"

“The fortifications are holding,” one of the elders replied smoothly. “But there has been movement in the eastern villages. Small raids. Disorganized.”

“Not yet a threat,” Mydei mused.

“No.” A pause. “But it will grow.”

Phainon barely registered the words. He was still focused on the way Mydei hadn’t reacted.

Fine.

Fine.

He let his weight settle against Mydei’s lap again, grinding down adeliberately, knowing exactly what it would do to him.

Mydei inhaled sharply through his nose, jaw tightening.

Phainon bit back a smile.

Not so composed after all.

“Then increase the garrisons,” Mydei said, smooth again—only slightly delayed, only slightly strained.

Phainon hummed against his skin, satisfied.

He could feel the next breath Mydei took, slower this time, measured.

And then, fingers pressing against Phainon’s waist—firm, insistent—before Mydei shifted up again, reciprocating somewhat.

Phainon barely smothered the gasp that tried to claw its way out, his back going taut, his grip on Mydei tightening as he clawed now.

He barely had time to recover before Mydei was speaking again. “Dismissed.”

The elders stood without delay, their discussion concluded.

Phainon, however, was still trembling in Mydei's lap, the weight of the meeting now replaced with something else entirely.

The chamber doors opened. The court left.

And Mydei finally looked at him.

"You survived."

Phainon gave a slow blink, the weight of exhaustion settling behind his ribs like a stone. He was still braced against Mydei, still curled in his lap, aching in places he hadn't even known could ache. And Mydei was watching him with something almost entertained in his gaze.

"Is that so?" Phainon muttered. His voice was rough, throat tight from holding back too many sounds. He shifted, feeling the deep, insistent soreness between his legs, the lingering heat that hadn't quite faded.

Mydei didn't answer with words. He exhaled, slow and measured, and then tilted his head—mouth grazing the curve of Phainon's jaw, breath warm against his skin.

Phainon barely had time to react before Mydei was kissing him again.

Not gentle. Not patient. He caught Phainon's lower lip between his teeth, nipped hard enough to make him gasp, then swallowed the sound, pushing in deeper. Their tongues met, slick and insistent, saliva mixing as Phainon clutched at his shoulders. It was messy, heated, his own breath stolen between the press of Mydei's lips, the wet slide of it making him lightheaded.

He barely registered Mydei shifting beneath him, barely noticed the hands sliding down his back until fingers curled tight around his hips.

And then—

A sharp pull.

Phainon gasped, back arching as Mydei forced him down, dragging him over his cock in one rough, unrelenting thrust. The stretch burned, still sensitive from before, but Mydei didn’t slow. Didn’t let him adjust. Just used his grip to force him into a rhythm, rolling his hips up as he slammed Phainon down over and over again.

“Wait—” Phainon’s hands scrambled for purchase, nails digging into Mydei’s arms. The wet, obscene sound of it filled the throne room, his rim stretched tight around Mydei’s cock, dragging along every inch as he was made to take it.

“Too much?” Mydei murmured, though there was nothing apologetic in the way he snapped his hips up, grinding deep.

Phainon dug his nails in harder, barely able to get the words out. “You wish.”

The answering laugh against his throat was downright sinful, pleased. Mydei angled his thrusts, hitting deep, hitting right, and Phainon’s next breath left him in a broken moan.

Phainon wasn’t about to let Mydei have the upper hand. Not now, not here.

So when Mydei’s grip tightened, forcing him down harder, Phainon braced himself and moved with it—rolling his hips, meeting every thrust with just as much force. If Mydei wanted to ruin him, he’d make sure to drag him down with him.

The next time Phainon slammed down, he bit at Mydei’s throat, sucking hard enough to bruise. His teeth scraped over salt-stained skin, his tongue tracing the hollow of Mydei’s collarbone as he worked a mark into it.

Mydei exhaled sharply, his breath hitching for the first time. But if anyone thought this was over, they were wrong.

A second later, Mydei dipped his head, mouth dragging over Phainon’s chest before closing around his nipple. His tongue flicked over the peak, teasing, before he sucked—hard.

Phainon choked on a breath, his back arching instinctively. The sensation shot straight through him, adding another layer to the heat already burning in his gut. He tried to keep his rhythm, tried to keep riding Mydei just as fast, just as rough—but Mydei bit down, and Phainon nearly lost it.

“Damn you—” His voice cracked, his hands trembling where they clawed at Mydei’s shoulders.

Mydei hummed, pleased, before turning his attention to the other nipple—his hands still moving, still forcing Phainon’s hips into that relentless pace.

Phainon grit his teeth, refusing to give in. He sucked another bruise into Mydei’s throat, then bit down again, harder, right at the base of his jaw. Mydei’s fingers twitched against his waist, his rhythm faltering for just a second.

Good.

Phainon suppressed a smile against his skin, rolling his hips with purpose now, taking Mydei deep, pulling every reaction he could get from him.

He bit down again, this time at the hinge of Mydei’s jaw, then dragged his mouth down, marking a path along the taut muscle of his throat. He moved lower, catching the edge of his collarbone, the curve of his chest. Open-mouthed kisses, bruising bites, sucking hard enough to make Mydei shudder beneath him.

A low sound left Mydei’s throat, barely audible, but Phainon felt it where their bodies were locked together, felt it in the tremor of his hands, the way his fingers dug into Phainon’s waist as if trying to steady himself.

Phainon was about to say something—something teasing, something to rub it in—but then Mydei shifted, one arm tightening around his back as the other slid lower.

Phainon barely had a second to process it before fingers curled around his cock.

His breath hitched, his hips jerking reflexively as Mydei's grip tightened, stroking him in time with every thrust. Phainon gasped, his nails dragging down Mydei's chest, his whole body trembling now, burning.

"What's wrong?" Mydei said, voice rough, amused. "Weren't you just gloating?"

Phainon wanted to bite back, wanted to retort Mydei and continue their banter, but the pressure was too much, the sensation winding hot and unbearable inside him. His thighs clenched around Mydei's hips, his rhythm faltering as pleasure tore through him, sudden and shattering.

His breath broke into a ragged moan, his whole body going taut, his vision white at the edges as heat spilled between them. He barely had the sense to muffle the sound against Mydei's shoulder, barely had the strength to keep moving as Mydei held him through it, dragging it out, leaving him shaking in his arms.

Phainon exhaled, hard, his chest heaving, his mind sluggish from the force of it. But Mydei wasn't done.

Because even now, even as Phainon slumped against him, spent and breathless, Mydei was still buried inside him, still thick, still aching.

And if Phainon had just lost this round, he knew Mydei was about to take full advantage of the next.

He barely had the strength to stay upright. His limbs felt heavy, his skin flushed and slick where he rested against Mydei's chest, his breath still uneven. He could feel the thud of Mydei's heartbeat beneath him, steady, grounding.

For a moment, neither of them moved. The only sound was their breathing, the distant crackle of torches still burning along the chamber walls. Phainon's body ached, but the weight of Mydei's arms around him was solid, reassuring in a way he wouldn't admit aloud.

Then Mydei shifted, pressing his lips—light, almost absentminded—against Phainon's temple.

"Still with me?" The words were softer than before, without the teasing edge. Just warm, quiet, something close to concerned.

Phainon exhaled against his shoulder. "Barely."

Mydei huffed a quiet laugh, his hands smoothing over Phainon's back, his touch slow, steady. It wasn't rushed now, wasn't insistent. Just tracing the shape of him, the curve of his spine, the press of his ribs beneath sweat-damp skin.

Phainon shivered—not from cold, not from exhaustion, but from the warmth of it, the gentleness.

He loved how good it felt.

A hand tilted his chin up, and before Phainon could think to do anything, Mydei kissed him—deep, unhurried, coaxing him back into the moment. It wasn't the rough, biting thing it had been before. This was slower, molten, a hand cupping the back of his neck as if Mydei had no intention of letting him pull away.

Phainon sighed into it, letting himself melt, letting himself be guided as Mydei's lips parted against his, as their tongues brushed, as the kiss deepened into something that made the rest of the world fade.

He almost forgot where they were, almost forgot the ache in his limbs, almost forgot that Mydei was still inside him—until Mydei shifted, hips rolling upward in a slow, deliberate movement that sent a shudder straight through him.

Phainon gasped against his mouth, fingers digging into his arms.

"Can you take more?" Mydei said softly, lips brushing against his own.

Phainon hesitated, his body still thrumming from the last peak, but the way Mydei was touching him, the way he was waiting—watching him so

closely—made something in his chest go tight.

He swallowed, pulse quick, and forced himself to meet Mydei's gaze, smiling as he let his hand rest on Mydei's cheek, caressing it. "I'm not that fragile."

Mydei smiled, not mocking this time, not sharp. It was quiet in a way that made Phainon's breath catch—before he lifted Phainon's hips and started moving again, this time with nothing between them but fervor.

The hours blurred together in a mess of heat, sweat, and pleasure. Phainon had lost count of how many times Mydei had pushed him to the edge, how many times he had gasped against his mouth, how many times he had sunk down only to be dragged back up and fucked even deeper.

By the time Mydei's pace grew erratic, his grip tightening, his breath ragged against Phainon's skin, Phainon was barely holding himself upright. His thighs trembled with the effort, his body so overstimulated he could barely breathe, barely think—just feel.

And gods, he felt everything.

The way Mydei's hips snapped up, the way his hands gripped bruises into Phainon's waist, the way his cock dragged against everything raw and sensitive inside him, stretching him open like he was made for this.

Mydei cursed, burying his face against Phainon's shoulder as he finally spilled deep, the warmth of it filling Phainon until he swore he could feel it in his bones.

Phainon shuddered, overstimulated, body twitching in the aftermath. His head lolled forward, forehead pressing against Mydei's, their breaths mingling, too exhausted to move, to speak.

They stayed like that for a long moment, chests rising and falling in tandem, their bodies still tangled together.

Mydei exhaled, slow, steady, his fingers easing their grip, his touch turning soft as he smoothed a hand up Phainon's spine, grounding him, keeping him close. Phainon, too drained to resist, just let himself sink into it, their temples resting together as the last of the tension faded into something quieter.

Neither of them spoke. They didn't need to.

Then, without warning, Mydei turned his head away.

"Don't look at me like that," he muttered.

Phainon blinked, tilting his head. "Like what?"

A muscle in Mydei's jaw twitched. "Just—don't."

Phainon huffed a quiet laugh, exhaustion making his voice rougher, lazier. He shifted against Mydei's lap, feeling the warmth of him, the steady rise and fall of his chest. "Would you rather I close my eyes, then?"

Mydei didn't answer.

Phainon leaned in, brushing his lips against the curve of Mydei's cheek, not quite kissing him, just close enough to feel the warmth of his skin. "You're terrible at pretending you don't care."

A sharp exhale. Mydei's hands twitched against his waist.

Phainon dragged his fingers through the damp strands of Mydei's hair, pushing them back, taking in the sight of him—the flush high on his cheekbones, the tension still lingering in his shoulders, the way his lips parted slightly like he had something to say but couldn't find the words.

Phainon didn't push. He just smiled, slow and knowing.

"Don't worry, Mydei," he murmured, letting his forehead rest against his. "I like it when you care."

A sigh ghosted against his lips. Mydei's hand drifted up his back, dragging lightly over sweat-damp skin before settling there, fingers splaying wide. His touch was absentminded now, less of a claim and more like he was reassuring himself that Phainon was still there. That he wasn't about to slip away the second the moment passed.

Phainon turned his head slightly, pressing his mouth to Mydei's temple, lingering there before whispering, "Don't leave again."

He felt the way Mydei tensed, the way his breath hitched just slightly.

For a moment, there was nothing. Then—

"I won't."

Soft. Steady. No hesitation.

Phainon's eyes opened, searching Mydei's face. Mydei met his gaze fully this time, nothing guarded, nothing hidden. Just certainty, sincere and unwavering.

Something in Phainon's chest eased. He swallowed, exhaling against Mydei's skin before muttering, "You better not."

A chuckle went through Mydei's chest, and before Phainon could protest, he shifted, arms bracing around him as he lifted them both with infuriating ease. Phainon barely had time to react before Mydei's grip tightened, holding him close.

"Come," Mydei murmured, his voice warm against Phainon's ear. "Let's clean ourselves up."

Phainon let out a slow breath as Mydei carried him, muscles aching, exhaustion settling deep in his bones. He could feel the steady rise and fall of Mydei's chest, the slow, measured rhythm of his breathing. It was grounding.

"I could walk, you know," he said, though he made no effort to move.

Mydei hummed, unimpressed. “Could you?”

Phainon absentmindedly replied, “Yes.”

A pause. Then, with deliberate slowness, Mydei loosened his grip just enough for Phainon’s toes to brush against the cold floor. The moment Phainon shifted, his thighs protested violently, trembling so hard that Mydei didn’t even try to hide his smirk.

Phainon dug his nails into Mydei’s shoulder, jaw tight. “I take it back.”

“Of course you do,” Mydei muttered, adjusting his hold and pulling him back up with ease.

Phainon grumbled something under his breath but didn’t protest this time, just let himself relax against Mydei’s warmth. His head dropped onto Mydei’s shoulder, breath ghosting against his skin.

They were quiet for a moment, the tension from before replaced by something softer. Mydei’s grip on him gentled, fingertips tracing absentminded patterns along his spine. It was ridiculous, really—how something so brutal could end in something so careful.

“You’re warm,” Phainon muttered, voice quieter now.

Mydei’s hand stilled for a fraction of a second before continuing. “…So are you.”

Phainon exhaled a quiet laugh, tilting his head just enough to brush his lips against Mydei’s collarbone, barely more than a ghost of a touch.

“Good,” he said.

Mydei didn’t respond, but Phainon could feel the way his grip tightened ever so slightly, how his breath hitched just a fraction. And that was enough.

The warmth of the bath awaited them, the tension of the night slowly unraveling into something softer, something neither of them dared put

words to just yet.

For now, Phainon just let himself stay as he closed his eyes and rested, he'd made his choice.

———

Μείνε κοντά μου.
Stay close to me.
If war comes, if the gods demand their due—stay close to me.

Chapter End Notes

> Alright not even gonna lie this was pretty rushed halfway through cause I actually needed to end this soon to update my other works😭
>
> Oh yeah I have this problem where if I don't write smut in 2 weeks, I forget how to so I tried my best on that but it's probably bad/rushed but give me a pass please
>
> If I ever have the time I'll come back and revise this but I still hope it was an enjoyable read, thank you <3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!